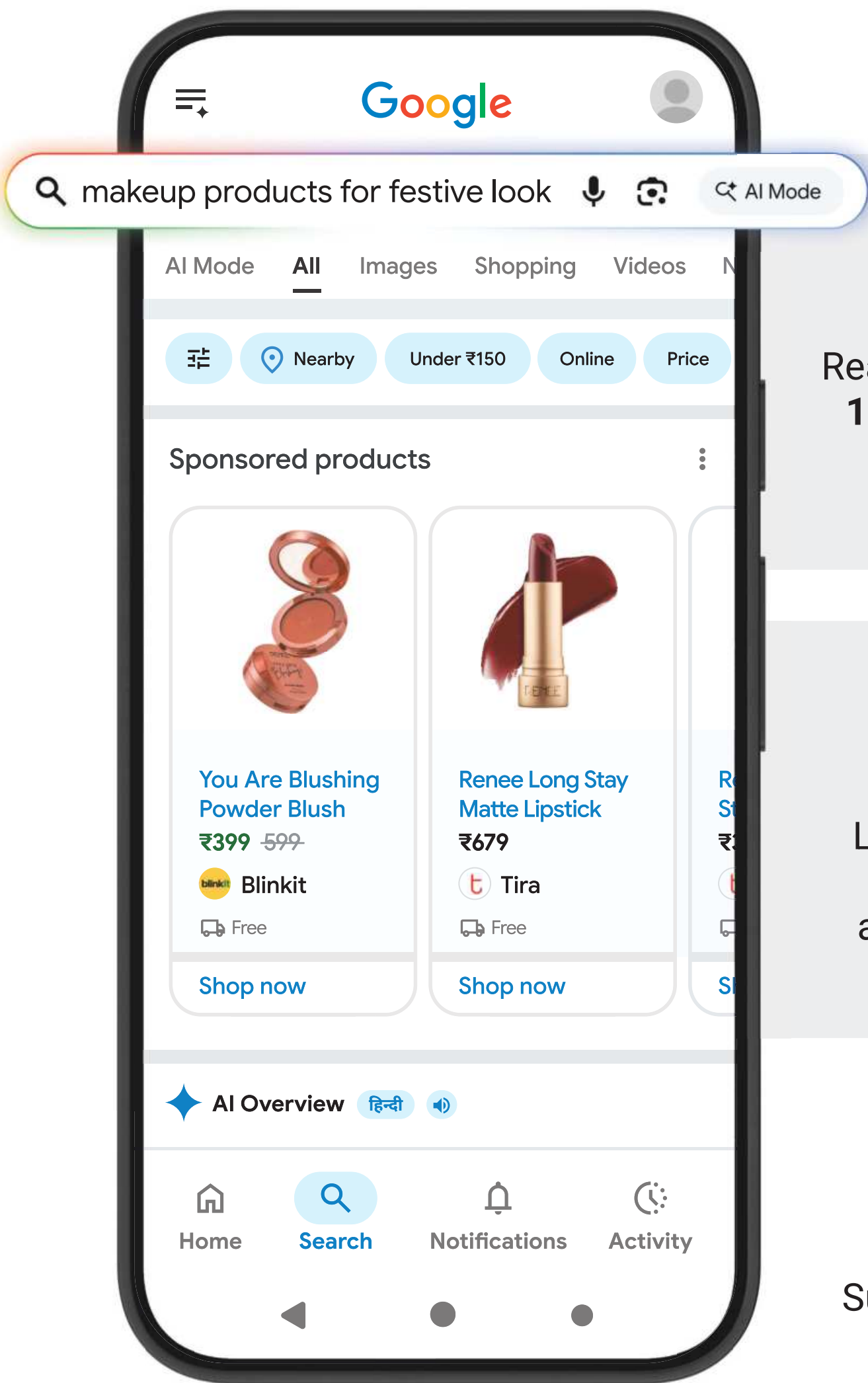




Modaks, New Looks & Festive Decor

Turn every festive Search into business growth



RENÉE

Reached more shoppers, driving
11.5% incremental sales with
Commerce Media Suite

tira

Leveraged **AI Max** to expand
its reach on Google Search
and grew purchases by **35%**



Supercharge decision-making
this festive season



Simulated UI for creative purposes. Results may vary. Some elements edited or created with AI

Drive festive business growth



87%

of **Google AI Overview** or **AI Mode** users in India agree they're able to make more confident decisions because of them¹



1.47x

Google Search ROI was 1.47x of Total Media ROI²



Supercharge decision-making this festive season



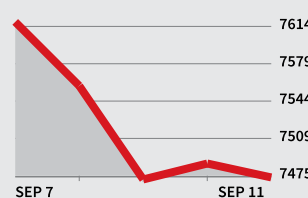
Sources:

- 1. Google commissioned Ipsos Global Consumer Journeys, Dec 2025
- 2. Commissioned Analytic Edge MMM Meta Analysis 2021-2025

*Some elements edited or created with AI

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74781.76 (-1733.67)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23398.10	-499.60
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.81	-0.46
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.55	+1.07
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151330.00	-2934
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	228920.00	-6536

CURRENT ACCOUNT.

Gold loan boom draws large NBFCs seeking safer, secured lending opportunities amid credit concerns **p9**



SPARK.

Watch microbrands blend heritage and craftsmanship, carving space between mass and luxury brands **p8**

MONDAY SPECIALS.

CORPORATE FILE

All that glitters... in jewellers' IPO boom

Dalal Street is experiencing a glittering gold rush as India's \$85 billion (₹7.3 lakh crore) jewellery market — long dominated by family-run shops — is formalising at breakneck speed. Driven by skyrocketing bullion prices and a consumer shift toward trusted brands, a staggering 12 mainboard and nine SME jewellery players have gone public since FY24 to fund ambitious expansion plans. **p7**



thehindubusinessline.
greet its readers
on the occasion of
Vinayaka Chaturthi
Our offices will be closed on
Monday, September 14,
for Vinayaka Chaturthi.
Consequently, there will be
no issue of the edition
dated Tuesday, September 15.
Readers can access the online edition at
www.thehindubusinessline.com

Govt to unveil cloud policy to ring-fence critical data

SOVEREIGN SHIFT. Framework may mandate air-gapped solutions to isolate systems

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The Government of India is expected to announce a unified cloud sovereignty framework in the coming days, aimed at ensuring that all government entities retain control over the country's mission-critical data, sources told *businessline*.

Following consultations with local cloud service providers (CSPs) and industry stakeholders, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has drawn up a list of parameters for government entities to consider when working with cloud and network service providers.

These parameters include the deployment of air-gapping solutions within the adopted cloud infrastructure, particularly in the case of international CSPs.

ISOLATED SYSTEMS

In an air-gapped setup, critical systems are isolated from external networks, allowing them to continue operating independently even if connectivity with a cloud provider's overseas infra-



COST LEVERAGE. The development comes at a time when cost advantages, supportive policies and data localisation are positioning India as a regional data centre hub

structure is disrupted.

Such a solution physically separates information networks to protect India's sensitive data, even when hosted on foreign hyper-scaler platforms. It can be thought of as a security measure beyond localised datasets, where the information is isolated even from cloud or Wi-Fi networks.

"Today, you have virtual private clouds, private clouds and government-certified clouds. None of these incorporates the concept of an air-gapped environment. For example, if a hyper-scaler's connectivity with its home country is cut off, the system in India would con-

tinue operating because it is air-gapped. That demonstrates resilience in running cloud infrastructure," a source told *businessline*.

The overarching intention is to understand sovereignty and develop possible strategic resilience checks, particularly for government bodies that currently use a mix of cloud offerings.

CLOUD SOLUTIONS

Different government bodies across India utilise various cloud solutions, ranging from the Meghraj cloud, managed by the National Informatics Centre (NIC), to private cloud services.

According to Commu-

nications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, the government currently has about 14 cloud partners.

DATA SOVEREIGNTY

The proposed framework would require government entities to assess factors such as the origin of cloud platforms, whether Indian or foreign, their operational independence from parent companies, compliance with Indian data protection laws and regulations, exposure to foreign legislation such as the US CLOUD Act and the Patriot Act, server locations, and kill-switch mechanisms.

"The idea is to develop a practical definition of sovereignty. During consultations, all CSPs spoke about control and improvement. Ultimately, the objective is to differentiate between local and international players and strengthen control mechanisms," said a source familiar with the discussions.

The development comes at a time when cost advantages, supportive policies, and data localisation are positioning India as a regional data centre hub.

'Weaponisation of critical minerals, tech could hinder shared progress'

Amrit Sen
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday warned that the weaponisation of technology and critical minerals could become a hurdle to shared progress and called on BRICS countries to ensure inclusive access to technology while pursuing growth that balances development with environmental sustainability.

"The weaponisation of technology and critical minerals can become a hurdle in our shared progress. Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in technology adoption," Modi said at the session on "Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability: Shaping the Future for Inclusive Global Growth" on the concluding day of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi.

CHINA DOMINANCE

The remarks assume significance as China's periodic export restrictions on critical minerals and related technologies have raised concerns over supply-chain vulnerabilities and economic coercion.

Chinese President Xi Jinping, who visited India after seven years, was also at the session, with other leaders



Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaking at the BRICS Summit

and representatives from the bloc, partner countries and outreach countries.

Xi's meeting with Modi on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit on Saturday has increased expectations of solutions being reached on various concerns on trade and investments from both sides, including assured supplies of rare earth elements and magnets, but border tensions remain a challenge.

Modi said the grouping needed to strengthen resilience and ensure that the benefits of solutions developed within BRICS were also adaptable and accessible to countries of the Global South.

The PM observed that the trust of Global South countries in BRICS had grown over time. "Because their voices are heard in BRICS, their experiences are respected, and solutions are made not just for them, but together with them," he said.

Outlining new initiatives, Modi said consensus had been reached on a BRICS integrated early warning system for infectious diseases, and that early warning data integration guidelines had been prepared for disaster management. "The BRICS Logistics Supply Chain Co-operation Framework will help make our supply chains more reliable and resilient," he said. On innovation, Modi pointed out, the 'BRICS Incubator Network' will connect start-ups and incubators with each other.

SCALABLE SOLUTIONS

"To promote innovative and scalable solutions, we have proposed the BRICS Startup Innovation Fund," he added.

Stressing the need to make farming high-tech, the PM noted that the BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture will create new possibilities for farmers, through which AI, geospatial technology and digital public infrastructure will be connected with the real needs of farmers, Modi added.

BRICS cooperation should not be limited to governments, Modi said. "Our entrepreneurs, farmers, researchers, women, youth, and ordinary citizens should also become its active participants".

More reports on p3

Rising copper prices may push up EV, appliance costs

Our Bureaus

Electric vehicles and consumer appliances are likely to cost more, as the price of copper — a key raw material — has soared above \$14,000 a tonne.

Indian industry, mainly automobile, electronics, telecom, infrastructure, construction and agriculture, is likely to bear the impact of rising copper prices. The surge has left the industry in a dilemma on how much cost it has to bear and how much to pass on to the consumer. However, some of them are indicating a hike in prices within a short span of time.

Solar module makers and data centres, which are seen as the current factors driving the metal prices higher, are, however, switching to aluminium as an alternative.

After rising to a record high of \$14,858 a tonne, the red metal's prices ended at



\$14,240 during the weekend.

COST BURDEN

The 14 per cent surge this year leaves manufacturers with the option of either having to absorb the increase, extract savings elsewhere, substitute materials or pass on a part of the burden.

Maruti Suzuki faces an estimated ₹204 crore of incremental monthly exposure, Tata Motors ₹171 crore and Mahindra & Mahindra ₹110 crore, according to industry estimates and calculations corroborated by *businessline*.

The increase is from an as-

sumed \$9,500-a-tonne benchmark, translating roughly into ₹10,000-13,000 of additional underlying copper cost for an ICE (internal combustion engine) car, more than ₹40,000 for some electric cars and ₹1.27-1.52 lakh for an electric bus.

COPPER SULPHATE UP 6X

For white goods, the corresponding increase could reach ₹3,300-4,300 for a 1.5-tonne split air-conditioner and ₹1,300-1,800 for a double-door refrigerator.

In the agriculture sector, prices of copper sulphate, a key component of Bordeaux mixture used to control fruit rot disease, have increased over six times from ₹80 a kg to ₹500.

For the construction sector, the metal's prices have increased over 12 per cent between April and September this year, translating into an estimated 0.75-1 per cent impact on overall construc-

tion costs. At this stage, the sector finds it manageable.

An executive of a company that is a key supplier to Tamil Nadu's biggest electronics manufacturing enterprises said copper, tin and silver are the three most critical materials, and prices of all three have been volatile. "This has impacted margins, and many of us are renegotiating our long-term contracts into shorter ones," he said.

Aditya Chellaram, Executive Director at Bengaluru-based Featherlite Developers, said the larger pressure on the construction sector is indirect, as copper-intensive equipment such as transformers, DG sets, chillers, lifts and motors are seeing faster cost revisions from vendors.

More on p10

With inputs from Rohan Das, Chennai; AJ Vinayak, Mangaluru; Meenakshi Verma Ambwani, New Delhi; Aishwarya Nandakumar, Bengaluru, Amit Vinay Mohile and Vallari Sanzgiri, Mumbai

India emerging as attractive launch hub for satellite firms, says Agnikul

Aishwarya Kumar
Jyoti Bantia
Bengaluru

India is emerging as an increasingly attractive launch destination for global satellite companies, with space start-up Agnikul Cosmos receiving one to two launch enquiries every week, Co-Founder and CEO Srinath Ravichandran said.

"A large share of the enquiries is coming from international customers, as satellite operators increasingly seek dedicated launches to specific orbital parameters," he said. The trend comes as India's track record in satellite launch services and the growing credibility of its private space sector strengthen the country's position in the global market.

Read more on p10

PREPARATIONS GATHER PACE



DIVINE JOURNEY. People transporting an idol of Lord Ganesha to a 'pandal' ahead of the Ganesh Chaturthi festival in Kolkata. President Droupadi Murmu on Sunday greeted the public, saying the festival inspires us to move forward on the path of progress with new resolutions. **p11**

The AI slowdown debate picks speed

Why 'pacing the frontier' may open the door for China and India

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

On Saturday, Anthropic Co-Founder Dario Amodei aired the idea of 'pacing the frontier' in a lengthy blog detailing various cyber threats such as the recent OpenAI-Hugging Face incident (OAI-HF) as well as technology's intimidating ability to self-improve (called recursive self-improvement) far beyond the maker's expectations.

OpenAI Founder Sam Altman and Grok Founder Elon Musk voiced support for this call, sparking off intense conversations about the practicality of the move on a global scale, especially considering the ambitions of rivals in China.

Over the weekend, the entire AI community went into a frenzy over the 'pacing the frontier' idea.



Dario Amodei, CEO of Anthropic **BLOOMBERG**

Some questioned the veracity of an AI slowdown, while conspiracy theorists warned of "something having gone horribly wrong", especially as two Anthropic researchers quit, issuing stark AI warnings.

But what has become apparent is that the AI race has changed now — it has become focused marathons relating to different aspects of AI.

One concern, flagged even by Amodei, was how a slowdown in development by the biggies could give China a leg-up in winning the AI race. However, experts speaking to *businessline* hinted that the paced advancement could branch out into different tracks.

SPECIALIST TALENT

"American and allied strength across advanced semiconductors, dependable electricity at scale and specialist talent remain genuine constraints is real. Meanwhile, Chinese developers pursue efficiency, domestic infrastructure and alternative supply arrangements. A country does not need to lead every model benchmark to take a substantial position in the AI economy," said Sanchit Vir Gogia, Founder and Chief Analyst at Grey-

hound Research, pointing out further race tracks like general reasoning, offensive cyber capability, inference economics and industrial deployment.

While Chinese developers are already competitive across important model-performance and open-weight categories, America still controls the most coveted AI component — the NVIDIA chipset. So much so that even Amodei suggested against the sale of powerful AI chips or semiconductor manufacturing equipment to China.

India, meanwhile, must strengthen AI oversight and engage more actively in global governance, said Sidharth Deb of The Quantum Hub. "We need to look at that quite seriously, especially given that the UNGA is later this month."

SEBI's CAS tweak: Market participants still prefer earlier settlement methodology

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) proposed changes to the new closing auction session (CAS) are expected to make price discovery less disruptive and resolve many practical problems, but early reactions from market participants still suggest a preference for the more familiar system of using volume-weighted average price (VWAP) for derivatives settlement.

DUAL OPTIONS

The market regulator has proposed two options for the settlement of index and single-stock derivatives on expiry days.

One would immediately shift to a blended VWAP, using trades during the last 30 minutes of continuous trading and the 10-minute CAS.



The other would revert to the pre-CAS method of using only the last 30 minutes of continuous trading for at least a year before moving to the blended methodology.

The removal of indicative index values could be particularly useful in reducing distortion during the auction, Feroze Azeez, Joint CEO at Anand Rath Wealth, said. "The indicative prices were creating volatility without any actual trades taking place. We saw the Sensex in-

dicative level move by thousands of points based on orders that were never executed," he said.

CAS also saw instances of aggressive orders moving indicative prices before being cancelled, potentially benefiting derivatives positions. "The issue was not the @3 per cent band itself... Making orders beyond 1 per cent more binding tackles the real problem by reducing the scope for such manipulation," Azeez said.

CAS CONCERNS

The proposed operation changes, however, have not necessarily shifted the preference towards CAS as the basis for derivatives settlement, as a blended VWAP is seen as adding unnecessary complexity by making settlement dependent on two different trading mechanisms.

Uttam Bagri, promoter

director at BCB Brokerage and former chairman of the BSE Brokers Forum, backed retaining the last 30-minute VWAP while extending cash market trading to 3.30 pm, followed by the auction session and a five-minute derivatives window, instead of the current 3.15 pm cut-off. Trivish Dinesh, COO at Tradejini, echoed the view, saying, "The objective should be to have a settlement methodology that is transparent, easy to understand, and consistent for all market participants."

Trader and sub-broker forums largely favoured retaining VWAP, citing its simplicity and established use in expiry settlement.

Anand James, Chief Market Strategist at Geojit Investments, said the different settlement options proposed by SEBI also reflected the need for CAS volumes to improve.

QUICKLY.

Patent Office proposes new pharma patent guidelines

New Delhi: The Indian Patent Office has proposed updating guidelines for examination of pharmaceutical patent applications to improve the quality and uniformity of scrutiny, taking into account the evolving interpretation of laws by courts. It has issued draft guidelines for examination of pharmaceutical applications for patent. "To bring in quality, consistency and uniformity, the office has introduced the guidelines for examination in certain key areas like pharmaceuticals," it said.

Rail freight loading grew by 5.4% in August

New Delhi: Indian Railways loaded 137.9 million tonnes of freight in August this year, compared to 130.9 mt in August 2025, registering a 5.4 per cent y-o-y growth, officials said. "The increase in freight movement reflects growing demand from key sectors," Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said in a note.

UP expects more from ₹62,500 crore mobile phone manufacturing scheme

REAPING BENEFIT. More you produce and sell, more the incentive; other hubs will also benefit, says official

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The Centre's ₹62,500-crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS), is likely to take Uttar Pradesh to the next level of mobile phone manufacturing, from large-scale assembly to deeper localisation and exports, a senior State government official told *businessline*.

The State has emerged as India's biggest mobile manufacturing base, accounting for around 65 per cent of the domestic mobile phone production.

Global companies like Samsung, Oppo and Vivo are already manufacturing mobile phones here at large scale, alongside domestic contract manufacturers including Dixon Technologies, Optimus, Padget Electronics, Zetwerk and



MASS MARKET. India manufactures over 33 crore mobile phones annually, with about 100 crore in use BLOOMBERG

Bhagwati Products, the official said.

Most of these facilities are located in Noida and Greater Noida belt, which is now being extended to around Jewar Airport, at Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA). "If disbursement broadly tracks output, a very substantial share of the ₹62,500 crore will be earned by units operating in Noida, Greater Noida and

the Yamuna Expressway belt," said the official.

More than 75 electronics companies have invested over ₹28,000 crore in UP, and semiconductor-related projects now exceed ₹32,000 crore, he noted.

MPMS does not start that process, it protects and extends it. It tells a manufacturer who is deciding where to put his next line, that the policy environment will remain predictable for five

years, from FY27 to FY31, the official explained.

"MPMS is not a capital-allocation scheme with State-wise quotas. It is an incentive on eligible sales — you produce, you sell, you earn the incentive. So, there is no envelope marked 'Uttar Pradesh' sitting in a file in Delhi," he added.

According to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), in 2014-15 only 26 per cent of the mobile phones being sold in India were made in India. But today, 99.2 per cent of all mobile phones sold in India are made domestically. The manufacturing value of mobile phones has surged from ₹18,900 crore in FY14 to ₹4.22 lakh crore in FY24.

RISE IN EXPORTS

More than 32 crore mobile phones a year are being manufactured locally and

about 100 crore mobile phones are in use in India. The exports, which were almost non-existent in 2014, have now surpassed ₹1.29 lakh crore.

Apart from UP, Sriperumbudur in Tamil Nadu has a cluster housing large-scale manufacturing and assembly units for global partners like Foxconn and Apple supply chains. There are other emerging clusters also — like in Telangana, Maharashtra and Karnataka where component manufacturing and final assembly are happening.

The MPMS was notified on August 21, and according to Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Electronics and Information Technology, the design, intellectual property and brand must be Indian-owned and capable of competing with the best products in the respective market segment.

Nayara shipped 70% of Russia's oil product imports from Vadinar

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Rosneft-backed Nayara Energy exported roughly 1.20 lakh tonnes of petrol to Russia at \$90 million from its Vadinar refinery in Gujarat in August.

"India supplied 70 per cent of Russia's oil product imports (94 per cent of its gasoline imports) in August, 120,000 tonne of gasoline (€ 78 million), all of it loaded at the Vadinar refinery and sold by EU-sanctioned Nayara Energy and bought by Rosneft," said a report by Finland-based Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA).

In August 2026, Moscow imported 172,000 tonne of oil products (€114 million). Russia's import volumes in August 2026 were more than seven times the previous monthly high that was recorded since the full-scale invasion and three times the total import volume for the whole of 2025, CREA said.

Gasoline accounted for 74 per cent of Russia's total oil product imports in August, compared with just 6 per cent between 2023 and 2025, it added.

CAPTIVE INFRA

Rosneft holds 49.13 per cent of Nayara Energy, and Vadinar took 100 per cent of its crude from Russia in the first eight months of 2026, up from 81 per cent across 2025, it said.

"Russia is therefore paying a refinery that it partly owns to process its own crude into fuel it can no longer produce domestically, before shipping it back halfway around the world. Each cargo exported from India's Vadinar refinery to Russia was transferred between vessels in a ship-to-ship operation at the Damietta Lightering Zone off Egypt before unloading at Russia's Arctic port of Beloe More," it added.

The CREA report pointed



out that Russia typically imports only small volumes of refined oil products, averaging less than 5,000 tonne per month of seaborne imports between 2023 and 2025. No cargoes of imported fuels were unloaded at Russian ports for 13 of those 36 months.

Most of Russia's oil product imports from Ukraine's allies consisted of gasoline and clean products from South Korea, supplying Pacific ports that are difficult to reach by other routes. After repeated waves of Ukrainian drone strikes targeting Russia's energy and refining infrastructure, Russia has for a while been facing severe domestic fuel shortages.

On the other hand, after two consecutive months of record-high crude oil imports from Russia, India's shipments decreased by 24 per cent in August month-on-month, CREA said.

"Imports by all three of India's largest Russian crude-importing refineries remained high in August: the Jamnagar refinery (fell 15 per cent m-o-m), Vadinar refinery (rose 5 per cent) and Paradip refinery (increased 1 per cent)," it added. The IndianOil Vadinar SMPL installation imported a significantly lower quantity of Russian crude oil in August, down 48 per cent from the prior month. Meanwhile, imports of Russian crude at smaller refineries, such as HPCL Mittal Energy (HMEL) Mundra Oil Terminal, decreased by 34 per cent m-o-m.

Supply of 40 Airbus aircraft to Def Min to attract GST: AAR

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Airbus will need to take GST registration in Gujarat for supply of aircrafts to the Defence Ministry, Gujarat AAR has said. The Tata group company is assembling aircraft on behalf of Airbus in its plant at Vadodara.

"The applicant (Project Office) is liable to pay GST in India on the supplies of 40 aircrafts made to the Ministry of Defence, Government of India pursuant to the platform contract," AAR said in a ruling pronounced on September 11.

The entire process of manufacture (by Indian



IMPLICATION. The ruling is relevant for contract manufacturing businesses, where the manufacturer and the final supplier are not the same REUTERS

Aircraft Contractor or IAC) and subsequent supply of 40 aircraft to the MoD, ex-works (outward supply), by the applicant, is being carried out in Gujarat. Further, the present

threshold limit/exemption limit for goods in States (other than special category states) is ₹20 lakh. However, "the transaction value of the aircraft to be supplied to the MoD in Gu-

jarat is ₹1,914.5 crore." Hence, the project office needs to be registered in the State from where supply is to be made.

WIDER RELEVANCE

Commenting on the ruling, Amit Maheshwari, Managing Partner at AKM Global said, "What makes this ruling interesting is that the AAR has looked at the transaction from the standpoint of the actual contractual flow, rather than simply asking who manufactured the aircraft." The fact that title passed to Airbus at Vadodara and the aircraft were thereafter supplied to the Ministry of Defence from the same location be-

came important in determining the GST liability. This could have wider relevance for businesses operating through contract-manufacturing arrangements, where the manufacturer and the entity making the final supply are not necessarily the same, he added.

Moreover, the government being the recipient does not, by itself, mean that the supply is exempt. "The absence of a specific exemption for aircraft meant that the supply remained taxable, with the AAR consequently placing the requirement to obtain a separate GST registration in Gujarat, given that the taxable supply was be-

ing made from the State," Maheshwari said.

TOTAL DEAL

Spain based Airbus Defence and Space (having a project office namely Airbus Group India Pvt Ltd at Gurugram) was awarded a contract in 2021 for the supply 56 C-295MW aircraft along with associated equipment.

Out of these first 16 aircraft will be delivered at Airbus Defence and Space SA facilities in Spain, in fly-away condition. Remaining 40 aircraft will be manufactured in India by Tata Advanced Systems Ltd the IAC. These will be supplied to Airbus, who then supply to Defence Ministry.

PwC India and US to create a consulting joint venture to be spearheaded out of India

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

PwC US and PwC India on Sunday announced a joint venture that brings together their advisory capabilities across India and the US.

The consulting major said it is combining PwC India's and PwC US' India-based capabilities into a single platform to serve clients globally.

REVENUE BOOST

The JV will be an Indian entity with about 40,000 people and will have a 50.1 per cent share of US equity and 49.9 per cent India equity.

The entity's revenue is estimated at around \$1.5 billion from day one, and PwC expects it to boost the consulting firm's growth potential and advance its goal of tripling revenue by 2030.

"Today, clients are a lot



Sanjeev Krishan, Chairperson, PwC India

more global. What we have done is something which is a first in the professional services world. We are saying that the local market is maturing very fast and are trying to make sure that Indian partners and teams have the best of the global capability to serve their most important clients," Sanjeev Krishan, Chairperson of PwC India and the incoming CEO of the new joint venture, told *businessline*.

"Another reason is the growth of our GCC business, which has grown manifold over the last 2.5 years. We believe the opportunity is even more significant, and many of the decisions relating to US corporations with GCCs in India are being made here in India," he added.

DEAL TIMELINE

The transaction is expected to close in the first half of calendar year 2027, subject to closing conditions and regulatory approvals. Until then, PwC US and PwC India will continue to serve clients through their existing structures and ways of working.

The financial terms of the agreement were not disclosed. The joint venture will be owned and governed by PwC US and PwC India.

In terms of changes in the style of operations, Krishan says nothing will change in the way the entity will trans-

act with clients, but when it comes to the engagements, they will now bring a more holistic point of view. "In fact, for GCCs, we will contract and deliver more from India post-JV," he said.

COMBINED STRENGTH

"We're bringing the full breadth of our advisory talent in India together with PwC US — one team with the relationships, expertise, and scale to deliver for our clients and the PwC network. This isn't about where work gets done. It's about building something clients can't get anywhere else: the best of PwC, brought together around their biggest opportunities, wherever they operate," Paul Griggs, PwC US Senior Partner and CEO, said.

The resulting platform will address all elements from strategy and transformation through technology, engineering and AI.

Related parties of personal guarantor will not have a say in deciding on repayment plan: IBBI proposal

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Related parties of a personal guarantor will be assigned zero voting share on the repayment plan and creditors will have to record their deliberations and reasons for approving or rejecting a payment plan, as per an Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India's (IBBI) Discussion Paper.

The paper has been floated for public comments for strengthening safeguards in the Insolvency Resolution Process for Personal Guarantors to Corporate Debtors.

The IBBI is contemplating the aforementioned measures in the wake of a NCLT (New Delhi Bench) order in late-August that okayed a repayment plan presented by Essel Group founder Subhash

Party connected to the debtor will get 'Nil' voting rights and the resolution professional has to indicate whether a creditor is a related party, says IBBI

Chandra, whereby creditors were to receive ₹6.25 crore against admitted claims totalling about ₹22,000 crore.

However, this repayment plan was subsequently stayed by a larger NCLT Bench on lenders' plea. Subsequently, IBBI has planned four amendments, including exclusion of related parties of the guarantor from voting on the repayment plan; recording of creditors' deliberations

on the repayment plan; identification and reporting of avoidance transactions (preferential, undervalued, fraudulent, and extortionate credit transactions) in the insolvency resolution process of the debtor; and valuation of assets of the personal guarantor in the resolution process.

RELATED PARTY

The IBBI has proposed that a related party of the guarantor shall be assigned a "nil" voting share. It is further proposed that the list of creditors prepared by the resolution professional separately indicate whether a creditor is a related party of the guarantor.

The insolvency regulator noted that a party connected to the debtor should not be permitted to influence a vote on a matter from which its connected

debtor stands to benefit. This proposal seeks to rectify this anomaly.

Where the amount proposed to be paid to creditors under the repayment plan is significantly lower than the amount of their admitted claims or the estimated realisable value of the assets of the guarantor, the creditors should specifically record the commercial rationale for considering approval of the repayment plan as a better alternative to the decision of initiation of a bankruptcy process, per the paper.

IBBI said this requirement would promote transparency, accountability and informed decision-making by creditors, and would ensure that approval of a repayment plan rests on an objective assessment of the recovery prospects reasonably available to them.

Civil Aviation Minister outlines larger transformation plan for Chennai Airport

Our Bureau
Chennai

Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu on Sunday outlined a larger transformation plan for Chennai Airport, including expansion of passenger capacity, a planned Terminal 5 and a stronger focus on passenger experience.

He said Terminal 5 is now in the planning stage and, with a planned capacity of around 20 million passengers annually, could take Chennai Airport's overall capacity to approximately 55 million passengers. A new ATC technical block is also being planned.

Speaking virtually at the inauguration of the passenger pick-up plaza at Terminal 1, Naidu said the airport's



Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu virtually inaugurating the pick-up plaza at Chennai airport on Sunday

ongoing modernisation, involving an investment of around ₹2,500 crore, is expected to raise its annual passenger-handling capacity from about 20 million to 25 million.

The work on the new terminals is expected to be

completed by April 2027. Naidu said the expansion was necessary as Chennai Airport handled around 23 million passengers in 2025, compared with 13 million in 2013-14.

He described Chennai as one of the country's flagship

airports and said the Centre would give greater focus to its transformation.

Located about 30 m from Terminal 1, the passenger pick-up facility is intended to ease the difficulties faced by arriving passengers, particularly elderly travellers and families, who earlier had to walk to the multi-level car park to access cabs.

Minister Naidu said Digi Yatra registrations at Chennai Airport had risen to about 35 per cent from around 12 per cent a year ago.

He said the Ministry would also introduce QR codes across the airport to collect passenger feedback and use it in future planning, stressing that passengers should be treated as the major stakeholders in the airport's transformation.

BIPA calls for integrating biological inputs into conventional agriculture to cut chemical use

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The BioAgri Input Producers Association (BIPA), an association of agricultural biological companies, has called for a 25 per cent reduction in chemical fertiliser and pesticide use through the scientific integration of biological inputs.

BIPA has urged the government, industry, research institutions and academia to jointly develop a national programme to improve soil organic carbon, which it considers fundamental to the long-term health and productivity of Indian soils.

"India needs to move from a predominantly chemical-dependent agricultural model towards an integrated system in which biologicals and chemicals work together

scientifically and responsibly. A phased 25 per cent reduction in chemical fertiliser and pesticide usage can deliver significant economic, environmental and agricultural benefits," according to A John Peter, President, BIPA. India consumes around 35 million tonnes of urea annually and depends substantially on imported raw materials for DAP, potash and other fertilisers.

With the annual fertiliser subsidy bill exceeding ₹1.75 lakh crore, BIPA believes that reducing chemical dependence could help contain subsidy expenditure and foreign exchange outflows.

"These efforts could help save the country ₹40,000 crore annually, besides reducing import dependence, lowering farm input costs, improving soil health and strengthening the competit-

iveness of Indian agricultural exports," he said in a statement here on Saturday.

INTEGRAL PART

He said biological inputs such as bio-fertilisers, bio-stimulants and bio-pesticides should not be seen merely as substitutes for chemical inputs, but should be scientifically integrated into the existing agricultural system.

He said biological inputs can support nutrient availability, beneficial soil microorganisms and sustainable crop protection, thereby enabling farmers to progressively reduce their dependence on chemical inputs without compromising productivity when appropriately selected and used.

The association will hold the sixth Annual BioAgri Industry Summit — BIOAGRI

2026 on October 7-8 here on the theme "Biological Intelligence & Smart Agriculture."

The association said restoring soil biological activity should become an important component of India's agricultural policy, with greater emphasis on sustainable nutrient management, microbial activity and improved soil resilience.

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QUICKLY.

Chinese President Xi pitches AI vision

Chinese President Xi Jinping has sought to turn the annual BRICS summit into another platform for championing Beijing's vision for artificial intelligence, as it vies for global influence over the technology with the US. China will lead the creation of what Xi called a BRICS "community" for open-source AI. Speaking on Sunday in New Delhi, he said the initiative will "support the cooperation in developing and applying large language models," as well as holding AI seminars and training courses for members of the club of major emerging economies.

EEPC seeks elimination of non-tariff barriers

Kolkata: The country's apex engineering exports promotion body, EEPC India, on Sunday called for eliminating non-tariff barriers and having a smooth payment mechanism among BRICS nations to boost trade. EEPC India Chairman Pankaj Chadha said an agreement on non-tariff barriers between BRICS nations is the need of the hour.

Iranian President slams West over sanctions



New Delhi: BRICS must expand trade in national currencies and work towards an inclusive global economic framework as excessive dependence on existing financial and trade systems has made emerging economies vulnerable to political shocks, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Sunday. In an address at the concluding session of the two-day BRICS summit, Pezeshkian, taking a swipe at Western powers, was also critical of "unilateral sanctions", saying they are directly impacting global food security and people's welfare.

Business Alliance calls for enabling women-led businesses to garner scale

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

BRICS Women's Business Alliance has called for measures that will help women-led enterprises and businesses to scale while enabling more women entrepreneurs to move from participation to leadership across markets. BRICS WBA, which released its annual report on Sunday, has made various recommendations including creating the right conditions for women-led enterprises to grow by enabling them better access to capital and innovation.

Avarna Jain, Chairperson, BRICS Women's Business Alliance, said, "For BRICS to realise its full economic potential, women must have the opportunity to build, own and lead at scale. Women-led development must therefore not sit alongside the BRICS growth story; it must help define it."

CREATING JOBS

She added that while women are building businesses, creating jobs, driving innovation, and contributing to growth, the next step is to enable more women entrepreneurs to move from participation to leadership, from small enterprise to scale, and from success in one market to opportunities across BRICS." Its recommenda-

businessline.

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India and China are partners, not rivals or threats, says Xi Jinping

BRICS BONHOMIE. Chinese President calls for stronger economic ties, parallel progress on boundary issues

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Chinese President Xi Jinping, in his two-day visit to New Delhi for the BRICS Summit on September 12-13, sought to project India-China relations as a partnership rather than rivalry and a development opportunity rather than threat, calling for greater economic cooperation as well as joint shouldering of responsibility towards the Global South amid international turbulence.

With Beijing taking over chairship of the forum next year, Xi pitched for a stronger BRICS role in countering unilateralism, tariff measures and growing geopolitical conflicts while supporting multilateralism and the WTO.

On the border issue, the Chinese formulation differed subtly from India's emphasis. Xi called for "parallel, mutually reinforcing progress" in advancing bilateral relations and resolving



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping during the BRICS Summit 2026 in New Delhi

the boundary question while maintaining peace and tranquillity along the border. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in contrast, stressed that peace and tranquillity in the border areas was an "essential basis" for the continued development of bilateral relations.

COMMON INTEREST

"China and India are partners rather than rivals, and development opportunities rather than threats to each other. This is a strategic judgment made based on the development stage and international environment of the

two countries, and one that conforms to the common interests of the two countries and the two peoples... help each other succeed in the spirit of win-win cooperation," Xi said at his bilateral meet with Modi on Saturday, per a statement issued by the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

The emphasis on economic ties comes amid bilateral trade touching a record \$151 billion in FY26, though the balance remains heavily skewed in China's favour, with exports from China to India at \$131.6 billion.

Xi, who visited India after

seven years following the border tensions in Galwan in 2020, said the recent resumption of institutional exchanges and expansion of the cooperation list had not come easily and should be "cherished".

He also linked closer India-China ties to their larger role in the Global South, saying the two most populous countries and major developing economies had an important responsibility amid a "changing and turbulent international landscape".

US TARIFF REGIME

The comments come as the US tariff regime and continuing conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine have disrupted trade, supply chains and energy security.

In his BRICS address, Xi made a broader case against rising unilateralism and power politics, saying these were undermining multilateralism and the international order.

He called on BRICS to support the multilateral

trading system with the World Trade Organization at its core, advance WTO reform, oppose the abuse of tariffs and reject protectionism. "Today, changes unseen in a century are accelerating across the world. The Global South is gaining strength, and the trend toward a multipolar world is unstoppable. At the same time, unilateralism and power politics are surging against the tide, lashing at multilateralism and the international order," Xi said.

The BRICS New Delhi Declaration stitched together by New Delhi also expressed concern over unilateral tariffs and trade restrictions, underscoring the bloc's opposition to measures that undermine the multilateral trading system.

To promote technology and trade within the grouping, Xi proposed a BRICS initiative on AI-enabled new industrialisation and warned that "decoupling" and supply-chain restrictions would not stop development.

Modi, Xi offered to help end Ukraine war, says Kremlin spokesperson

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Russia has said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping offered to facilitate peace negotiations and help end the ongoing war in Ukraine.

Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov revealed that both leaders showed a keen interest in finding a peaceful settlement to the conflict. He confirmed that Russian President Vladimir Putin welcomed their willingness to assist.

"During their bilateral meetings, Modi and Xi took a keen interest in the Ukraine settlement and actively offered their good offices to help find a solution," Peskov said.

CRITICAL JUNCTURE

The initiative comes at a critical juncture as persistent efforts by US President Donald Trump to broker a peace deal between Moscow and Kyiv continue to face hurdles.

The camaraderie among the three leaders was evident during the summit's opening

day, where Modi, Xi and Putin walked together and held hands, signalling unity amid ongoing global geopolitical fractures.

During a bilateral meeting with Putin, following their previous interaction at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit in Bishkek, Modi reaffirmed India's commitment to diplomatic solutions. Modi reiterated that "dialogue and diplomacy" remain the only viable path forward to resolve conflicts, emphasising that India stands ready to support all peace efforts.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, the leaders also deliberated on critical regional issues affecting maritime trade and the security of Indian seafarers, particularly ongoing instabilities in the Black Sea and West Asia regions.

On the economic front, both nations discussed expanding bilateral trade and advancing the implementation of their Programme for Economic Cooperation 2030 across sectors including energy, defence, infrastructure, technology and culture.

Putin asks BRICS to consider Swift alternative, grain exchange

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Stressing that trade within BRICS member countries has reached \$1.2 trillion, Russian President Vladimir Putin on Sunday sought 'a closer look' on his proposals — establishing a BRICS payment, depository and clearance infrastructure, a reinsurance mechanism, and a grain exchange — terming those as highly promising.

Though India has clarified that there is no proposal to float a common BRICS currency, the members are increasingly moving to set up BRICS Pay as an independent digital payment and clearing infrastructure as an alternative option of systems like Swift, in which trade set-

tlement will be in local currencies.

Similarly, setting up a reinsurance company within BRICS will help insurers in member countries not to wholly depend on existing players in Europe and the US.

CME ALTERNATIVE

businessline had reported in October 2025 about the move to set up the BRICS Grain Exchange (BGE) as an alternative to the US-based futures trading platform CME.

Alleging biases on platforms like CME, Russia has told BRICS partners that BGE can save them \$2.5 billion annually. Before his departure, Putin attended the BRICS Outreach/Plus Session on the concluding day of



PM Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin on the second day of the BRICS Summit 2026

the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi. The Russian President highlighted that countries within BRICS possess their own channels for

the movement of goods, services and capital, which are independent of external market conditions.

"These already enable us

to conduct commercial, banking, financial and investment operations effectively, in the face of external pressure. I also invite everyone to take a closer look at the promising initiatives put forward by Russia to streamline our cooperation. These include establishing a BRICS payment, depository and clearance infrastructure, as well as setting up a reinsurance mechanism and a grain exchange within the association. I am convinced that both member states and partners of BRICS will be able to employ all these tools in the future," said Putin.

GROWTH PLATFORM

Amid continuing sanctions after war with Ukrain, Russia has also called for establishment of a common growth

platform for BRICS that would organically integrate the competitive advantages of the members' economies.

"It is crucial to build this platform on the principles of openness and accessibility, not only for BRICS members, but for all our partners and friends. I am confident that this is precisely what will happen," he noted.

HIGH POTENTIAL

The potential for the further development of BRICS is far from exhausted and one of the main untapped resources so far is the complementarity of the member states' economies.

The differences in the structure and specialisation offer vast opportunities for practical cooperation, for creating new production

chains, technologies, services, and markets.

Taking note of the BRICS nations' steady population growth and strengthened domestic markets, he said all the countries have established robust industrial, technological, financial and academic hubs, as well as modern transport, energy and digital infrastructure.

"Member states account for almost a quarter of global exports, and it is BRICS that, at 49 per cent, provides most of global GDP growth," he said.

Putin also called for further strengthening the capacity of the BRICS New Development Bank and updating its business model. The Bank has already financed 123 projects worth nearly \$40 billion.

Modi talks trade and investment with top leaders

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday held bilateral discussions with South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, Philippines President Ferdinand Marcos Jr, and Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El Sisi on the sidelines of the BRICS summit, with a focus on boosting trade and investment ties.

Modi also held a series of meetings with other global leaders, including Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, Burundi President Avariste Ndayishimiye, Ugandan Vice-President Jessica Alupo, and Nigerian Vice-President Kashim Shettima.

Officials said boosting co-operation in trade, investment, defence and people-to-people ties was a dominant theme at the meetings.

In a social media post, Modi said he and Ramaphosa reviewed the full breadth of the India-South Africa strategic partnership including cooperation in mining and critical minerals, infrastructure, food security, digital public infrastructure and emerging technologies.

"Our partnership is rooted in history and firmly focused on the future. We will work closely for Africa's progress, the priorities of the Global South and a more balanced global order," he said.

Business Council seeks supply-chain resilience framework, AI cooperation

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The BRICS Business Council has called for a supply-chain resilience framework as well as deeper co-operation in artificial intelligence (AI), digital infrastructure and advanced manufacturing.

The grouping brings together 11 key economies representing around 40 per cent of the global GDP. The Council on Sunday presented its report that has made recommendations focused on strengthening resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability.

Stating the recommendations are intended as a guide for the four pillars of India's BRICS Chairmanship, Jai Shroff, Chair, India Chapter, BRICS Business Council and Chairman and Group CEO UPL Ltd, added the BRICS represents "extraordinary economic strength".

SUPPLY CHAINS

"Recent years have demonstrated the importance and dependability of the supply chains, food, energy, security, modern infrastructure, and diversified production networks. The Council proposes a supply chain resilience framework for BRICS to strengthen information sharing and preparedness during the disruption," he added

He said the Council's report calls for deeper co-operation in AI, digital infrastructure, advancing manufacturing, connecting business, technology providers and innovation ecosystems across BRICS nations. "Technology is transforming every part of our economies across farms, factories, finance, logistics



Jai Shroff, Chairman, India Chapter, BRICS Business Council

and energy. Our ambition is not to simply adopt new technologies, but to innovate together," Shroff said.

The Council's report also emphasises on paperless trade, electronic documentation, and greater interoperability among digital systems.

Stressing that business sustainability must go hand in hand with energy security, affordability and industrial competitiveness, he said the report identifies opportunities for cooperation on green hydrogen, biofuel, sustainable aviation fuel and low-carbon fuels. "Such cooperation must be supported by progress in technology standards, infrastructure and financing. It can create new industries, value chains, investments, and employment across economies," Shroff said.

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BRICS and gaps

New Delhi meet showcases potential and chinks

To India’s credit, the just concluded BRICS summit in New Delhi was surprisingly purposeful given the differences between the 11 member countries in the wake of two ongoing wars, in the Persian Gulf area and Ukraine. The joint declaration reflects a mature attempt to create a common ground among the Global South to promote wide-ranging technological and social sector collaboration overriding divergent strategic interests. A disruptive US could well have acted as a catalyst here.

There can, however, be no denying that BRICS is a fractious grouping, with China exercising overweening influence. Even so, BRICS has managed to position itself as a countervailing force to the US accounting for 40 per cent of global GDP and 26 per cent of world trade. The US has been hostile to BRICS for strategic and economic reasons. First, BRICS is seen as a platform for China and Russia to expand their influence. Second, it posits an alternative global governance system, with a greater say for developing countries in ‘western’ institutions such as the IMF, World Bank, UNSC, UNFCC and WTO. Third, BRICS has been working at non-dollar settlement systems, at least to transact within its members and 10 partner countries.

It is notable that the declaration expresses the need in West Asia to maintain ‘smooth flow of global trade, supply chains and energy in accordance to international law’. Iran and the UAE, both BRICS members but in opposite camps, have signed on to this, even as the conflict has escalated in the region — a testimony to BRICS’ potential. Without naming US as an aggressor in any context, BRICS has called it out with respect to attacks on Occupied Palestine. It has assailed “indiscriminate” tariffs and non-tariff measures, and “protectionism under the guise of environmental objectives”, targeting both the US and EU. A BRICS currency has more or less been shelved, but settlement systems in local currencies have already picked up, more so in the shadow of sanctions on Russia after 2022. India has been at pains to clarify that it is not part of any ‘de-dollarisation’ project. But it can reduce transaction costs if it is able to trade in its currency and those of BRICS member countries. It has been doing so with Russia. However, this effort has to turn multilateral so that the third party demand for currencies other than the yuan increases even as technology makes such arrangements easier.

Meanwhile, China’s Cross Border Interbank Payment System, which is both a messaging and settlement network, has expanded in scope since February 2026 to allow multi-currency settlements. China accounts for over 60 per cent of BRICS trade and its surplus with the BRICS members, including India, has been rising over time. India surely cannot be comfortable with yuan emerging as the de facto BRICS currency. Its neutrality in BRICS lends credibility to the grouping. For BRICS to truly grow in stature, it must be less China-driven than it is now.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Controlling AI: humanity cannot outsource its survival
If there were a 10% chance that AI could wipe out humanity, no responsible government would leave its development to companies racing to build it. Yet until recently, that seemed to be the case. The warning was all the more ominous because it was made by a researcher at Anthropic, the trillion-dollar AI company behind the Claude chatbot. The dangers of AI-enabled pandemics or attacks on nuclear systems are real. Countries need not agree on democracy or trade policy to accept this. The US and China will hold, reportedly, their first bilateral AI-safety talks before a planned White House summit between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping. Despite their tech rivalry, neither Washington nor Beijing can make the most advanced AI safe on their own. A US-China settlement won't be able to say how AI works everywhere. Countries deploying AI must help write the global rulebook. The odds on an extinction event are shortening. (LONDON, SEPTEMBER 11)

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Trump’s real problem is real wages
The August inflation report came in stubbornly high on Friday, which means there’s no reprieve for the White House this election year, or for the Federal Reserve when it meets on monetary policy next week. Only if the Fed focuses on reducing inflation will President Trump get the lift in real wages that he presided over in his first term. The Labor Department on Friday reported that the consumer price index rose 0.4% in August, and 3.4% over the last year. While energy prices drove most of the monthly surge, that’s no consolation to consumers. (NEW YORK, SEPTEMBER 11)

LINE & LENGTH.

Another BRICS summit is over. China with its trade surpluses was clearly the overwhelming big daddy. It accounts for over 60 per cent of intra-BRICS trade and investment. Russia with its oil ran a close second. India trailed far behind with nine tail-enders. Many people in India are full of admiration for China’s economic success, like they were for Pakistan in the 1980s. But Pakistan went phut because it didn’t have the political systems and institutions to sustain growth. China has the same problem. From 1950 to 1980 we admired and copied the USSR which also went phut in 1990.

That’s why I always ask people who admire China if they would like to swap our political system and institutions with China’s. No answer is forthcoming. But let’s leave aside the politics and sociology and examine the India-China comparisons from a purely economic lens. The starting point has to be the acknowledgement that neoclassical economics is founded on the idea of political liberties, which China doesn’t permit. But we have a surfeit of these liberties. Chinese GDP, meanwhile, is \$20 trillion. Ours is not even five. So the question has to be whether the absence of such liberties facilitates rapid growth in industrial output. In China it does, but in the USSR it didn’t. The West also didn’t have full political liberties — of the sort we have had since 1950 — till about 50 years ago. You can check this out.

CAPITAL OR LABOUR
There can be no doubt whatsoever that political liberties and rapid economic

If Chinese political stability is ensured by massive force and widespread denial of political rights, Indian economic stability is ensured by suppressing economic freedoms. Which is preferable?

V Shunmugam

For three decades, the National Stock Exchange (NSE) has priced everything India owns except itself. That is about to change. The exchange filed its draft red herring prospectus on June 17, 2026, for 148.9 million shares, close to six per cent of paid-up capital. The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has since issued its observation letter. Before a traded price begins to summarise the exchange, its record and unfinished agenda deserve an audit. The record begins with an index. NSE created the Nifty and made it the benchmark for Indian equity risk. Its pull took a slice of India’s price discovery offshore, to a Singapore Exchange contract. The answer was construction, not a ban. Since NSE International Exchange began full operations at Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City) on July 3, 2023, the GIFT Nifty contract has recorded more than 69.56 million contracts and \$3.21 trillion in turnover. Next came operational credibility. In the mid-1990s, screen-based trading across a national network, straight-through settlement and a clearing corporation standing between every buyer and seller were rare. That is why foreign portfolio investors treated India as a destination, not an experiment. Registered investors rose



A tale of two systems

India-China comparisons don’t make sense. The two countries are chalk and cheese

growth are inversely related. When you expand one, the other contracts. The more you have of the former the slower will the latter be. Look at East Asia after 1990. There are no exceptions to this rule because growth depends on giving primacy to capital. Strange as it may sound, this is Marx 101. And it’s not just

China, all the ‘Asian Tigers’ were like that. This has been said by several Nobel winning economists as well. Unconstrained optimisation means capital flows into China and flows out of India. Period. Our emphasis on liberties means capital gets short shrift. All our laws favour labour because we are a rights-based society. And when we

NSE has priced everything except itself

By going in for listing, NSE offers investors an asset whose returns follow the market’s activity rather than its direction

from 30.87 million in March 2020 to 129.1 million in March 2026. The growth is no longer confined to metropolitan areas: Uttar Pradesh led new registrations in 2024-25, adding 29.5 lakh investors. The same instinct built institutions. In 1996, the exchange set up the National Securities Depository Ltd along with the Industrial Development Bank of India and the Specified Undertaking of the Unit Trust of India. The depository was listed last year, with NSE among its selling shareholders. The pattern extended to NSE Indices, NSE Data and Analytics, NSE Clearing, and the exchange and clearing corporation at GIFT City. Some capabilities were built and then handed over: acting on the Mahalingam Committee’s recommendations, the exchange exited its technology and skilling businesses in early 2025. Letting go of what specialists can run better says as much as the balance sheet.

UNUSUAL BALANCE SHEET
That balance sheet is unusual. Revenue from operations was ₹16,601 crore in FY26, with profit of ₹10,302 crore, both easing after SEBI’s derivative measures. Operating margins are near 76 per cent, net debt is zero, and the treasury book stands at about ₹64,771 crore. Roughly 51.2 per cent of global equity derivative contracts pass through the exchange, a position held for seven consecutive years, along with about 93 per cent of cash equity turnover.



BIG JUMP. Registered investors on the NSE have risen significantly. BLOOMBERG

What does listing add to an institution that is already considered a deemed listed entity, with disclosures, board, and conflict norms equal to or better than those of a listed company? The regulations remain largely the same; however, their enforcement varies significantly. Since the exchange lacks a promoter and the Life Insurance Corporation of India holds the largest stake at 10.72 per cent, ownership is widely spread; the listing will make the market the key oversight mechanism. The open agenda deserves equal attention. Listed companies have a combined market value of ₹41.1 trillion across nearly 3,000 firms, while the corporate bond market is a fraction of that and municipal debt is barely present. Commodity derivatives remain thin in an economy that lives off agriculture and now leans on manufacturing. The Emerge platform

try to correct the imbalance, as in 1991 or 2006 or 2019, there is protest. Just look at the number of trades unions and NGOs jumping up and down all the time and laying siege to the Supreme Court.

It must be asked why liberals object to a politically hard state, which is what we need for ever increasing investment and industrial output. You can’t have one without the other. It doesn’t work like that.

Also, when was the last time anyone compared Indian agricultural performance with China’s? India achieved food self-sufficiency in the 1970s, so much so that the massive drought of 1979 went unnoticed by the world. China is nowhere near it.

In fact, food is one of China’s biggest vulnerabilities alongside energy. It has enough of neither. All the world has to do is to reduce food and energy exports to China by 10 or 15 per cent and we will see how the paper tiger roars. India is quite safe that way.

We also have absolutely no idea of the efficiency of its capital use. The fact that the government’s first priority is employment, Chinese industry is hugely subsidised. That has created what economists call a moral hazard problem: there is very little incentive to save on capital. Few people realise it but China has made the same mistakes as the old Soviet Union where efficiency is concerned.

APPLE OR ORANGE?
The point I am making is that when you compare two entirely different systems of governance you shouldn’t just look at one part and draw large conclusions. The correct questions to ask must be about systemic stability: which countries have stable systems and which are resting on a pin?

If Chinese political stability is ensured by massive force and widespread denial of political rights, Indian economic stability is ensured by suppressing economic freedoms. Which is preferable?

What would happen if China allowed even a fraction of Indian political rights and India allowed a small degree of Chinese economic freedom? Neither is going to happen.

China has a lot of hugely subsidised economic competition. We have a lot of hugely subsidised political competition. You can choose between them.

That’s why we should stop admiring what we don’t have and start boasting about what we do and keep expanding those things. China has the economic brawn but not the political brain. And that is going to be its biggest long term liability.

for smaller firms was worth ₹1.8 trillion in March 2025. Retail’s share of market value reached a 22-year high of 18.75 per cent in the second quarter of 2025-26, but retail money still prefers short-dated derivatives to ownership. Each gap is a multi-year commitment that a listed company must defend every quarter. The offer structure is often misread. It is only an offer for sale, so the money goes to the selling shareholders and not to the exchange. The Life Insurance Corporation, the State Bank of India, other banks and development finance institutions have held the stake for decades at close to original cost. Listing turns a locked strategic holding into liquid capital when the primary market needs it. The timing is a test in itself. With a heavy pipeline lined up for the coming quarters, an issue of this size will measure domestic institutional and household demand better than any survey.

For regulators, the listing carries forward what corporatisation and demutualisation began. For investors, it offers an asset whose returns follow the market’s activity rather than its direction. For policymakers, the sharper question is not what the exchange has built, but which of the remaining gaps it will now be pressed to close, when 129 million investors can also be its shareholders and its performance is priced every day.

The writer is Partner, MCQube

● BELOW THE LINE



Xi skips PM dinner
One bus, one dinner — and one notable absence. Chinese President Xi Jinping gave Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s gala dinner a miss, even as Russian President Vladimir Putin and other BRICS leaders joined the host for the evening reception. Union ministers and chief ministers of several States were also present. In a touch of unusual choreography, the ministers and chief ministers

attending the dinner arrived at the venue in a single bus from Parliament, turning the journey itself into a small spectacle of the summit. **A musical at BRICS**
BRICS diplomacy acquired a distinctly musical note in Delhi on Saturday, with Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim, in the capital for the summit, being seen singing Kishore Kumar’s iconic “*Khwab Ho Tum Ya Koi Haqeeqat*” from the 1965 film *Teen Deviyen*. The unexpected rendition of the Bollywood classic offered a lighter moment amid the high-powered diplomacy surrounding the summit. **Fintech mysteries**
While the main stage buzzed with AI and tokenisation, much of the action at Global Fintech Fest was happening off it. Day one saw SEBI Chairman

and IOSCO’s top brass in not one but two closed-door meetings, with no livestream and little detail on what was discussed. Elsewhere, State Bank of India Chairman CS Setty was spotted working the crowd, despite not being on the public agenda for the day. Add another dozen or so such sessions across three long days, including those involving FATF and RBI, and even a private GIFT City interaction with the Finance Minister, and it seemed this year’s real fintech conversations were happening behind closed doors. Meanwhile, Sarvam AI set itself apart by livestreaming its entire ‘closed-door’ meeting but kept the media present at the venue out of the hall. **No easy answers**
At NSE’s pre-IPO press meet, perspective, reporters were

reminded, comes with time. NSE MD and CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan, responding to concerns over how the industry would navigate a tougher regulatory environment, suggested that reporters had not “tracked exchanges as a business long enough” to understand market cycles. Chauhan also made a rare switch to Gujarati when answering one query for the relevant audience. Questions on the lower price band and offer size were shrugged off to the investment bankers, none of whom were part of the answering panel, despite all 20 being present in the room. Invitations for the press meet went out only the previous midnight, while foreign media were conspicuously left out. **Money matters**
South African president Cyril

Ramaphosa made a pitch to Indian corporates to invest in the country. While most of Ramaphosa’s address at a CII organised roundtable focused on reforms and improved credit rating, he ended it on a lighter note that drew laughter. “Yesterday I went to the BRICS business forum I had a little bit of cold which I usually develop with too much air conditioning. So my sense of smell was little bit reduced,” the president said. “This morning I woke up a lot better. As I entered this room and because my sense of smell has improved greatly I could smell money. So meeting you here I have a greater sense that I am in the presence of people with money. So I want you to come and invest in South Africa,” he remarked. **Our Bureaus**

GREEN CAPITAL



SUSTAINABLE FINANCE. Indian investment in the manufacture of solar components grew rapidly from late 2023 through mid-2025 REUTERS

India grabs bigger share of global investment in solar manufacturing

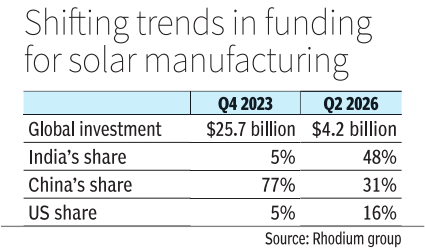
M Ramesh

India's share of global solar manufacturing investment has risen sharply even as investment worldwide has collapsed, with China accounting for most of the decline, according to the Clean Investment Monitor of the Rhodium Group.

India accounted for 48 per cent of global solar manufacturing investment in Q2 2026, up from just 5 per cent in Q4 2023. China's share, meanwhile, fell from 77 per cent to 31 per cent during this period.

The shift, however, needs to be read against a dramatic contraction in the global investment pool, industry insiders tell *businessline*. Global investment in solar manufacturing fell 83 per cent, from \$25.7 billion in Q4 2023 to \$4.2 billion in Q2 2026.

China accounted for 94 per cent of the global decline, with its investment falling by \$20.4 billion, or 92 per cent, over the period.



The contraction in China follows a substantial expansion of manufacturing capacity and growing domestic price pressure. Investment there fell by more than 30 per cent in both the first and second quarters of 2026.

India's investment, by contrast, grew rapidly from late 2023 through mid-2025. But that momentum has also weakened. Investment in India fell by more than a third in the two quarters from Q3 2025 to Q1 2026. The slowdown comes as US tariffs have effectively closed that market to Indian solar manufacturers, while the industry is also dealing with domestic overcapacity in downstream manufacturing.

Investment announcements, however, show that India continues to attract significant interest. In Q1 2026, India accounted for \$7.3 billion, or nearly half of the \$15.7 billion in global solar manufacturing investment announcements.

The picture changed in Q2, as the US dominated announcements with \$8 billion of the global \$10.4 billion. China accounted for \$1.6 billion and India \$667 million.

Two US projects — a \$2.9-billion solar cell plant under construction in Texas; and a \$2.9-billion cell-and-module project announced in New Mexico — together accounted for 56 per cent of global Q2 announcements.

Globally, investment recovered in the first half of 2026 to \$18.3 billion — more than double the \$7.9 billion in the second half of 2025. But it remained 32 per cent lower vis-a-vis the first half of 2025.

ONSHORING STRATEGY

US Section 232 move: Opportunity or fresh hurdle for Indian solar makers?

IMPORT BARRIER. The answer partly depends on the willingness, and financial capacity of Indian companies to set up factories in the US

M Ramesh

On August 6, US President Donald Trump issued a proclamation under Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act, citing national security concerns over dependence on imported polysilicon and its derivatives. The measure establishes minimum import prices (MIPs) of \$21 a kg for polysilicon, \$100 a kg for ingots and wafers, \$0.22 a watt for solar cells, and \$0.38 a watt for solar modules. It also imposes an additional 15 per cent *ad valorem* duty on covered polysilicon derivatives. The changes are set to take effect on December 4.

The twin measures — MIPs and tariff — are intended to make way for American manufacturers and counter China's cheaper alternatives. The proclamation also authorises an onshoring programme, potentially offering tariff-related benefits to companies investing in US production.

What does "Section 232 action" mean for Indian solar manufacturers selling in the US and/or setting up manufacturing facilities there?

The answer to the first part of the question depends on ongoing US investigation into Indian companies, which may result in high anti-dumping and countervailing duties.

The latter answer depends on the willingness (and deep pockets) of Indian companies to set up factories in the US.

The MIP effectively changes the competition equation in the US market. Until now, a major advantage enjoyed by Chinese and other low-cost suppliers was their ability to remain competitive even with percentage-based tariffs, because their manufacturing costs were low. A floor price upsets that equa-



MISSING LINK. There is a shortage of non-Chinese wafers in the US BLOOMBERG

tion: imports can no longer compete simply by being the cheapest.

This could give Indian manufacturers — particularly those with excess module capacity and those raising cell capacity — some room to compete in the US.

But Ayush A Mehrotra, Partner at Khaitan & Co, cautions against this interpretation. "The US could offer an incremental opportunity, but I would not characterise the Section 232 MIP itself as making the US an attractive export destination for Indian manufacturers," he told *businessline*. The measure, he pointed out, is intended to create a viable domestic market for US producers rather than favouring any foreign supplier.

Indian manufacturers also face uncertainty from anti-dumping and countervailing duty investigations. "Any increase in Indian exports to

and the latest measures could make it more viable for Indian companies that can meet the required quality, pricing and compliance standards," Gupta told *businessline*.

For ingot and wafer manufacturers, there is a clear and present opportunity. While there is no operational ingot/wafer plant in India yet, many companies have announced capex plans. For those that can start production quickly, a big market awaits since there is a shortage of non-Chinese ingots and wafers in the US.

Indosol Solar, a subsidiary of Shirdi Sai Electricals, said its ingot plant is almost ready. "US floor prices are \$100 per kg for ingots and wafers, creating strong arbitrage potential for our N-Type TOPCon monocrystalline wafers," said Balachander Krishnan, Chief Operating Officer, Indosol, adding that the company's wafers could "command premium pricing".

MANUFACTURING IN THE US

The August proclamation explicitly seeks to encourage companies to establish or expand US production of polysilicon, ingots, wafers and cells. Mehrotra believes this could be a more significant opportunity.

The US Commerce Department has already made preliminary determinations in the anti-dumping and countervailing duty cases against Indian crystalline-silicon photovoltaic cells. If the final duties are high, it will erase the benefit of Sec 232 MIP. For Indian manufacturers, the question is not whether the US has levelled the playing field for foreign suppliers. It is whether India will still be allowed to play on that field.

Hanish Gupta, Founder and Managing Director of Sunkind India, expects Indian cell makers will look more seriously at the US. "The US remains an attractive market,

"I expect some Indian companies to seriously consider manufacturing in the US," Gupta said, adding they would have to weigh capital and operating costs, skilled manpower, energy prices and the longer-term policy environment.

That would also raise a policy question for India. If Indian manufacturers divert a significant portion of their cell output to America, could the country's module manufacturing base face a shortage of domestic cells? How will it impact India's 'domestic content requirement' (DCR) programme?

The fear is that the government may clamp down on exports to force Indian wafer and cell manufacturers to serve the domestic market first. But that would be unwise, Mehrotra said.

"The answer should not be to discourage exports but encourage enough manufacturing capacity to support both domestic and export demands," he said.

Gupta similarly said India's DCR programme should continue to support domestic manufacturing while companies are encouraged to explore export markets.

There is, however, a sharply different view within the industry.

"The US market has been effectively shut for Indian cell and module manufacturers because of high tariffs and threat of further anti-dumping and countervailing duties," said Vinay Rustagi, Chief Business Officer, Premier Energies. "The new provisions under Section 232 worsen that situation. The policy is designed to restrict all solar imports in the US and further boosts prospects for local manufacturing."

That may ultimately be the central lesson of the Section 232 move: for Indian solar manufacturers, the US could be a bigger opportunity as a manufacturing base than as an export market.

GOOGLE IT

Sparing small rooftop-solar businesses the initial legwork

K Bharat Kumar

Most of the small businesses offering rooftop solar installation services are constrained by the time and effort needed to estimate the requirements of a potential customer before a sale can be concluded.

To offer a price quote, they will typically need to send an engineer to the customer site to measure the roof, estimate the impact of shade from nearby trees or physical structures, and determine the tilt angles needed for an installed unit.

REMOTE ASSESSMENT

Google, which recently rolled out its Solar API service, said its offering could help vendors with remote assessment capabilities. Without having to visit the site, engineers can generate 3D roof models and the financial proposals from their office or even a smartphone.

The service from the online search giant covers about 300 million rooftops in India and could well remove operational bottle-

necks for small installers while bringing down customer acquisition costs.

NO SOFTWARE EXPENSE

Solar Ladder, which offers project management, material procurement and financing services to solar businesses, has integrated Google's API data into its offering, according to a statement from Google. This enables local installers to offer prospective customers mobile proposals in just minutes during initial conversations, thereby "helping improve sales conversion rates significantly". Local installers can also save on the cost of buying expensive computer-aided design (CAD) and 'light and detection and ranging' (LiDAR) software or hiring layout engineers. In effect, small installers may get a leg-up in competing with larger players without any increase in investment.

At the country level, this could prove the nudge that the 'PM-Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana' scheme could do with. The scheme had intended to power millions of households with subsidised rooftop solar, but the effort has been beset by low



ISTOCK

execution speed and shortfall in site evaluation capacity.

Manual surveys for the 300 million rooftops across tier-2/ tier-3 cities and rural areas can be time-consuming, from a logistics perspective. Digital assessments could help accelerate the conversion from 'interest' to 'installation'.

The other benefit Google says it

building insights or detailed solar potential data per rooftop address. Platforms could pay based on usage volume, as thousands of local installers query rooftops through their apps.

'WAIT-AND-WATCH'

A small business owner who installs rooftop solar panels in Chennai said his team typically did not visit a potential client's premises — be it to measure the roof or size the terrace — before preparing a quotation. "We are yet to use online or cloud software tools. Generally, with the prospect's consent, we access their account with the power distribution company and evaluate the power use patterns in summer and winter over the previous two years or so. We then arrive at a potential requirement."

He added that his representatives did make one visit to collect the advance, during which they also review the premises. "When we already conduct pre-sales activity on a shoestring budget, it remains to be seen how a software tool can help bring down that cost. We will have to wait and watch," he said.

India's coal gasification push needs a Chinese technology bridge

Why India should explore access to China's decades-old coal gasification technology, rather than developing it from scratch

M Ramesh

Chinese President Xi Jinping's New Delhi visit for the BRICS summit came at a time when seven companies, including Adani and NTPC, have applied for incentives under the government's coal gasification scheme.

That coincidence is worth noting. China is the world leader in commercial coal gasification, while India is preparing to commit crores of rupees to take the technology into new territory — from simply burning coal-derived gas to making chemicals and fuels from it.

Coal is what India has in abundance (it also has thorium, but that is fuel for another day). India must use coal in an environmentally benign way. The answer is coal gasification — an area where China has technology and six decades of experience.

India is targeting 100 million tonnes of coal gasification capacity by 2030, which the government's new ₹37,500-

crore scheme aims to support. But the aim also is to produce syngas and downstream products such as urea, methanol, ammonia, hydrogen and synthetic natural gas.

India should use the opening to explore access to Chinese coal gasification technology, says Roger Kumar, founder of CASE Group, which has worked with coal gasification for several years.

"China is much more advanced and mature in coal gasification technology," Kumar told *businessline*. China has been working on the technology for more than 60 years and has developed not just gasifiers but also an ecosystem around them, including chemicals, fertilisers and other downstream industries, he said.

100 MILLION TONNES DONE

"The government is talking about gasifying 100 million tonnes of coal. I can say with a lot of responsibility that India has already gasified 100 mt of coal," Kumar said.

However, there is a difference



THE HINDU ARCHIVE

between what India has already been doing with coal gasification and what the new government programme seeks to achieve.

India has long used gasifiers for coal-to-thermal applications. Air and steam are generally used as gasifying agents, producing a nitrogen-rich combustible gas, commonly called 'producer gas', which can be burnt for industrial heat.

The new programme is essentially about coal-to-chemicals. Here the objective is to produce syngas of controlled composition to serve as a chemical feedstock. Oxygen, rather than air, is used along with steam to avoid introducing nitrogen from air into the syngas, making it a more suitable feedstock for chemical production. The gasification process also operates at

different pressures, temperatures and scales.

"The gasification itself is the common technology, but coal-to-thermal and coal-to-chemical are two different applications, with different requirements for the gasifier and the gas produced," Kumar said.

As coal-to-chemicals kicks off in India, the question is whether India can develop the necessary technology quick and cheap.

This is where China can help. NITI Aayog's 2025 workshop on gasification of India's high-ash coal had noted that Chinese manufacturers have become leaders in entrained-flow gasifiers, while that country has successfully built a large gasification industry despite having relatively high-ash coal. At the same time, the NITI Aayog report cautioned that India's coal, with ash content often in the 30-45 per cent range, presents special challenges involving ash chemistry, equipment matching and operations.

That means no scope for using an off-the-shelf gasifier. The technology

would have to work with Indian coal.

But Kumar argues that India should learn from China's experience, rather than spending decades developing the technology from scratch.

There is already a precedent. Talcher Fertilisers' coal gasification project has involved Chinese engineering expertise. Incidentally, Talcher Fertilisers is one of the seven applicants under the new incentive scheme.

The government, meanwhile, has made its scheme technology-agnostic and says indigenous technologies are encouraged. It expects the programme to catalyse investments worth ₹2.5-3 lakh crore.

The question, therefore, is not whether India should become self-reliant in gasification but how quickly it can become self-reliant — and whether using the best technology available globally, including from China, can get it there faster.

Following Xi's Delhi visit, the question acquires an immediate diplomatic as well as industrial relevance.

OFFICE BUZZ.

AI-led layering

As AI agents make greater inroads into workplaces, the middle layer is shrinking and organisations are flattening out. Delayering is



not new per se, as organisations have tried to remove hierarchies and flatten the organisation in the past too. But then the imperative was speed and agility. Now, in an AI-enabled operating model, there is redeployment of resources and role redesign in the middle level, as coordination is automated and fewer human managers are needed. But, says Deloitte, the organisation of the future is not a boss-free one. Human managers are taking on new roles such as AI orchestration, coaching, and oversight.

Meanwhile, even as AI agents gain ground, pessimism around them is growing too. Gartner even warns that by 2029, 30 per cent of employees laid off due to replacement by AI will need to be rehired. “When business executives look back on the early AI-era, they will realise their greatest mistake was believing that work automation was the point, when workforce amplification was the opportunity,” said Tori Paulman, VP Analyst at Gartner. The competitive advantage will go to those who build an AI-shaped organisation where AI value compounds by reshaping roles and allowing workflows to cross traditional boundaries, increasing velocity and reducing friction.

Women who master

Hackathons have become quite common. Yet, Logitech and Aspire For Her's nationwide all-women generative AI hackathon was



newsworthy because it drew nearly 1.29 lakh registrants from across India and earned a Guinness World Records title. Guinness World Records created a brand new award category

specifically to recognise female inclusion in emerging technology: ‘Largest Women-Only Generative AI Hackathon (Multiple Venues)’.

A part of Logitech MX's #WomenWhoMaster movement, this initiative equips women with practical skills in generative AI, low-code development, and machine learning.

The grand finale, hosted at Logitech's Chennai headquarters, brought together 112 finalists from over 15,000 colleges across 5,000-plus cities.

Kritika Yadav from Ramdeobaba University, Nagpur, emerged the national winner for ‘HerFinance’, an AI-powered financial resilience companion designed to help women better understand their money, risks and financial choices.

● GOLD RUSH

All that glitters... in jewellers’ IPO boom

BEHIND THE SHINE. Jewellery firms are racing to go public, but falling physical demand threatens long-term investor returns

Madhu Balaji

Dalal Street is experiencing a glittering gold rush as India's \$85 billion (₹7.3 lakh crore) jewellery market — long dominated by family-run shops — is formalising at breakneck speed. Driven by skyrocketing bullion prices and a consumer shift toward trusted brands, a staggering 12 mainboard and nine SME jewellery players have gone public since FY24 to fund ambitious expansion plans.

The sector is expected to balloon to \$130 billion by 2030, yet the IPO frenzy unfolds at a precarious crossroads. While record-high gold prices are artificially inflating revenues, actual physical demand is shrinking. As Prithviraj Kothari, Managing Director at RiddiSiddhi Bullions and President of the India Bullion and Jewellers Association Ltd (IBJA), points out, steep gold prices are hurting jewellery sales volume, even as sales value keeps rising.

According to VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments, the rising gold price and the formalisation of the hitherto unorganised industry are the primary factors behind the IPO rush.

The enthusiastic response to the earlier public offers is also spurring more players to join in, he adds. But the surge in listings at a time of weakened jewellery buying raises questions. Will the headline revenue growth alone translate into sustainable expansion and long-term shareholder returns?

FORMALISATION

CA Surendra Mehta, National Secretary, IBJA, explains how the lack of formalisation had impacted the industry in the past.

“Even banks were not giving industry status to jewellers. Now jewellers are becoming organised and compliant, and they are eligible to go for IPOs,” he says.

Rising gold and silver prices have necessitated more capital to run and expand jewellery businesses, he adds.

Additionally, jewellers are set-



Sparklers and lacklustre debuts on the exchanges

NSE/BSE	Jeweller	Listing price in ₹	Listing gain/loss %	Price change in % as at Sep 10
Mainboard	PN Gadgil Jewellers	830	73	-26
	BlueStone Jewellery and Lifestyle	510	1	68
	Senco Gold	430	36	-19
	PNGS Reva Diamond Jewellery Limited	375	-3	35
	Lalithaa Jewellery Mart	265	32	27
	Shanti Gold International	227.55	14	13
	Deepa Jewellers	221	25	-11
	Manoj Vaibhav Gems N Jewellers	215	0	-3
	Priority Jewels	200	15	13
	Shringar House of Mangalsutra	188.50	14	15
BSE SME	Motisons Jewellers	109	98	-85
	Shankesh Jewellers	103.30	11	-5
	Varyaa Creations	285	90	-90
	SMR Jewels	102.95	20	-5
	AJC Jewel Manufacturers	95	0	171
Nifty SME EMERGE	Yaashvi Jewellers	83	0	-2
	Manoj Jewellers	53.95	0	-44
	Kabra Jewels	243.20	90	-58
	Pushpa Jewellers	112	-24	-3
	Utssav CZ Gold Jewels Limited	110.05	0	368
Chennai-based GRT Jewellers signed an agreement on August 31, 2026, to acquire a 74.12% controlling stake in Tribhovanadas Bhimji Zaveri Ltd for ₹1,033.71 crore	Grover Jewells	96	9	171

Source: NSE, BSE

ting up their own manufacturing facilities instead of relying on small job workers.

GST accelerated compliance, according to Mehta, as jewellers recognised the need to record trans-

actions and operate within the formal economy.

IT'S COMPLICATED

The growing jewellery market forms the backdrop for the rush of

● LYONS RANGE GAMBIT

Calcutta Stock Exchange’s revival bid

In an era dominated by the NSE and BSE, the restart of India’s second oldest bourse appears an uphill task

Mithun Dasgupta

India's second-oldest bourse is attempting an audacious comeback from the brink of liquidation. After applying for a voluntary exit in February 2025, the Calcutta Stock Exchange (CSE) has abruptly pressed ‘pause’, triggered by a budget proposal from West Bengal's newly elected Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government. The State's planned revival of the 118-year-old exchange — where trading remains frozen since 2013 — seeks to challenge Mumbai's monopoly and position Kolkata as a major capital markets hub for eastern and north-eastern India. But first it must convince a sceptical Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) — the capital market regulator, and rewrite the rules of regional trading.

Can a regional exchange survive in an era dominated by the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE)? How does the city's financial community view this development?

ALL FOR IT

Chartered accountant Binay Kumar Agarwal, who was a broker with CSE since 1996, says a new business model can create a “vibrant” exchange. “If the country can create power, bond, and carbon exchange platforms, we can also build a new model to revive CSE,” he says. Many brokers share his view that the “double-engine” government — namely BJP-led Centre and State — may infuse new life into the exchange.

Following the demutualisation scheme enforced by SEBI in 2007, brokers’ shareholding in CSE stands at around 49 per cent, while around 51 per cent of the equity shares are held by corporate shareholders (non-trading members). Within the corporate shareholding segment, the BSE and the West Bengal Infrastructure Development Finance Corporation (WBIDFC) hold 4.99 per cent and 3.38 per cent, respectively.

The city's industrialists and its



FREEZE FRAME. Trading halted at Calcutta Stock Exchange in 2013

small and medium businesses are enthusiastic about the revival plan. “The Calcutta Stock Exchange is an enduring symbol of India's financial heritage and Kolkata's historic leadership as a centre of commerce and enterprise. Its proposed revival is an encouraging step towards strengthening eastern India's capital market ecosystem, widening access to capital, and creating new opportunities for businesses and investors alike. We look forward to seeing this proud institution reclaim its place in India's growth story,” says Aditya Vardhan Agarwal, Director, Emami Group.

Mamta Binani, president of MSME Development Forum (West Bengal and North-East), says the CSE's revival can foster entrepreneurship, especially among women, by providing the region's micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) a platform to raise capital at a lower cost and gain a competitive edge. MSMEs would be able to nurture themselves better as they will only need to compete with companies in the east, rather than a bigger pool countrywide, she adds.

Certainly there are advantages, as pointed out by West Bengal Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta in his Budget speech: “The revival of the Calcutta Stock Exchange would have multifarious advantages, including easier access to capital for eastern India, lower

costs of listing and trading, and create new jobs.”

ROUTE TO REVIVAL

But revival is easier said than done. There is no policy currently for the reopening of a regional stock exchange. CSE must wait for SEBI's nod, which would depend on a credible revival plan.

B Madhav Reddy, former managing director and CEO of CSE, sees it as a formidable challenge. With all employees removed, existing arrangements with the NSE and BSE ended, and most of the major listed companies migrating to the bigger national exchanges, CSE must rebuild its institutional and operational capabilities from the ground up.

According to Reddy, the immediate priority is to build a dedicated team capable of developing a credible business model for the exchange. “Reconstituting and broadening the board, inducting professionals with relevant market and technology expertise, and securing the confidence and support of existing shareholders would be critical first steps,” he says.

One potential route to revival, he suggests, would be a strategic partnership or merger with the Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India (MSE), formerly the Multi Commodity Exchange-Stock Exchange (MCX-SX), given its presence in western India.

“Such a partnership could provide CSE with access to infrastructure, technology and market expertise while creating a meaningful east-west financial market linkage between Kolkata and Mumbai,” he says.

CHALLENGES

“The revival of the Calcutta Stock Exchange is certainly possible, but it will be both operationally demanding and commercially challenging. While regulatory approval from SEBI is an important milestone, the true test will be in rebuilding liquidity and creating a sustainable ecosystem that attracts brokers, investors and issuers,” says Daman Juneja, Partner-IPO Advisory and Financial Reporting, Nangia Global.

History shows that bourses succeed only by consistently attracting trading activity.

“Today, the NSE and BSE collectively account for virtually the entire equity trading ecosystem in India. Even if CSE resumes operations, persuading investors, traders and institutions to route orders through another exchange will be extremely difficult without existing liquidity,” Juneja points out.

Moreover, the CSE would need to establish a clearing and settlement mechanism compliant with SEBI's current regulatory framework, either on its own or through strategic partnerships. Reliable post-trade infrastructure is fundamental to market integrity. Also, substantial and ongoing investments are essential to maintaining market confidence.

“Any meaningful revival would require alignment among CSE's diverse stakeholders on governance, capital infusion and long-term strategic direction,” Juneja adds.

Despite the challenges, several factors could work in CSE's favour: strong government support, potential to emerge as the capital market hub for eastern and north-eastern India, and a differentiated focus on regional enterprises. But the ultimate test would be in turning political willpower into daily market momentum.

Viveks — retired at 60!

Lessons from the closure of a beloved consumer durables retail chain

RETAIL ROYALTY



SHIV SHIVAKUMAR

My divisional salesman in Hindustan Lever (as HUL was then called), T Srikrishnaiah, introduced me to Viveks. Srikrishnaiah and his family had been shopping with the Chennai-headquartered consumer durables retail chain for more than 20 years and he was a great fan of it. I met BA Kodandarama Setty, the patriarch of Viveks. Even though I was in the FMCG sector, I wanted to meet him because I had heard so much about Viveks from everyone in Chennai retail. I was not disappointed.

I was impressed with Viveks in all my interactions with it. Knowing your customer is the cornerstone of all great retailers. Viveks was way ahead of its time in consumer innovations. It understood the middle class and the bottom of the pyramid better than most others, and introduced the hire-purchase scheme and the ‘chit 11 plus 1’ (which all jewellers use today) in 1965. Viveks had a passbook for each customer, and all its records were in paper form, which was phenomenal. Retailers like to lock in their consumers, and Viveks was the best at it.

All great retailers have friendly, helpful staff; Viveks had people who were with it for decades. On a Pongal day, at 7 am I went to the Viveks outlet in the city's T Nagar area and found all the employees were in, gearing up for the big sale day. When the doors opened, many of the employees were greeting regular consumers like family. I have rarely seen that camaraderie in retail formats.

Retailers need trust, and Viveks had plenty of that. People rarely questioned the prices at Viveks, unlike in almost every other retail outlet.



AFFORDABLE LUXURIES. Chennai-based retailer Viveks pioneered the hire-purchase scheme to build loyalty (B VELANKANNI RAJ)

The value proposition at Viveks was built around this trust derived from years of hire-purchase schemes.

Most big retailers in India tend to treat brands as vendors. I dealt with Viveks during my Nokia days, and they were always respectful of brands and realised the importance of having good brands merchandised well in their outlets.

They would insist that we train their frontline salespeople in the features and benefits of our models. I tried my best to convince them to take a big bet on mobiles, but like all big box retailers they were a bit conservative.

I wish they had pivoted to mobiles quickly; they would have been a force to reckon with. Many saw Viveks as conservative and they may well be right. Viveks was frugal with inventory and never used price as a lever.

What lessons does Viveks' closing have for other retailers? ● Online is here to stay and is a faceless disruptive force. Retail brands need to differentiate on service and experience. Retailers need to take a unified view of ‘online’ and ‘offline’. E-commerce is the best price comparison channel and hence “why buy from me?” is an existential

ing market share from unorganised competitors, who simply can't absorb the cost pressure as easily,” Kothari says.

Bafna says the next phase of growth would call for more disciplined capital deployment.

“The success of expansion will depend less on adding stores and more on choosing the right markets, managing inventory efficiently and building a product mix suited to changing consumer preferences,” he says.

WINNERS AND LAGGARDS

Of the 21 jewellery IPOs since FY24, the stocks of eight — BlueStone Jewellery, PNGS Reva Diamond, Shringar House of Mangalsutra, Priority Jewels, AJC Jewel Manufacturers, Utssav CZ Gold Jewels, Shanti Gold International, and Grover Jewells — were trading with significant gains from debut levels as of September 10. Recently listed Lalithaa Jewellery Mart also traded with modest gains.

Others have given up substantial listing gains, indicating their inability to deliver sustained growth.

Going forward, investors should focus more closely on sustainable volume growth, same-store sales growth, inventory efficiency, margin expansion and brand strength, rather than headline revenue growth alone.

HSBC's brokerage arm has stated that the key framework for evaluating companies in the expanding listed jewellery universe should be growth, execution and return on capital employed (RoCE).

It noted that jewellery businesses need a huge working capital, so rapid growth can weaken operating cash flows. HSBC's framework also considers store expansion and industry trends, leverage, performance stability, promoter background and track record.

Beyond the listings, Tribhovanadas Bhimji Zaveri's acquisition by GRT Jewellers offers a clear trend. (TBZ shares zoomed nearly 94 per cent to a 52-week high on September 9, before declining in the last two sessions.)

The deal suggests that consolidation could prove another route to scale, alongside IPOs and store expansion.

daily question for retailers.

● Retail brands need to manage their consumer base in a proactive manner. In an era where televisions dominated electronics retail, sporting events and related activity drove footfall. Today, a new phone is launched almost every week and that drives more traffic to retailers than any television brand. A move away from managing once in a few years to managing on a quarterly basis is needed. For this, retailers need to tie up with brands proactively.

● Family firms need clarity on how to move forward, how to pivot despite the pulls and pressures of different family factions. I see this drift happening across businesses in which more than two family members are involved. Every family member is aligned when things go well. When things slow down and investment is needed for growth, that's when families need to look ahead and not protect their narrow base.

A great innings from Viveks ends. It was a pioneer and an innovator. Other retailers copied it blindly. Now who will set the innovation?

Shiv Shivakumar is operating partner at Advent International and former chairman of PepsiCo India

FUND FACTS.

\$100 million

Garagepreneurs Internet Private Limited received funding from Moore Strategic Ventures, Kado Global, Neo Wealth, Neo Asset Management, Blume Ventures, DSP Investments, and Raise Financial Services on September 3, taking the total funding to \$363 million.

\$70 million

Ultrahuman Healthcare Private Limited received funding from Blume Ventures, Nexus Venture Partners, Qualcomm Ventures, Labcorp, Alpha Wave Global, and Alteria Capital on September 3, taking the total funding to \$168 million.

\$63 million

Karam Safety Private Limited received funding from Motilal Oswal Private Equity on September 9, taking the total funding to \$83 million.

\$50 million

Lagom Labs Private Limited received Series C funding from Footpath Ventures, Peak XV Partners (Sequoia India and SEA), Filter Capital, and Mirabilis Investment Trust on September 7, taking the total funding to \$72 million.

\$40 million

Herspace Manufacturing Private Limited received funding from Gray Ghost Ventures on September 7, taking the total funding to \$50 million.

Source: PrivateCircle Research, a private market intelligence platform

RE POSTS.

- ✕

every great founder i know has a phase in their story where they were just embarrassingly broke and irrationally confident at the same time

mal

@mal_shaik
- ✕

Being a founder means making important decisions with about 60% of the information you wish you had.

Andrew Gazdecki

@gazdecki
- ✕

as a founder you have precisely 23 minutes to celebrate a win until you have to put out the next fire

Tyler Denk

@denk_tweets
- ✕

The curse of discipline is that every day looks the same. The curse of indiscipline is that that every year does.

Hemant Mohapatra

@MohapatraHemant

WELL-TIMED

What keeps these newbie brands ticking

WATCH LIST. A new crop of startups are assembling timepieces with distinctive styling, midway between mass and luxury brands



DIAL UP THE DESIGN. Younger watch brands are positioning themselves as objects of identity, sentiment and personal taste

Aishwarya Kumar

For Vanshika (name changed), a watch became a way of keeping her grandmother close. When a piece of her grandmother’s jewellery was passed on to her, she wanted to preserve it in a form that would stay with her. Her grandmother had a simple suggestion: “A watch,” she recalls her saying. Her father, a Kolkata resident, approached Jaipur Watch Company to incorporate the heirloom jewellery into a watch. The resulting piece is now part of Vanshika’s wedding trousseau, stunning in its intricate designs and motifs, which modern-day *karigars* may no longer make, she says. “It will remain forever,” she adds. Another watch enthusiast, who declines to be named, says that the appeal of a new crop of Indian watch microbrands lies in the stories and traditions embedded in their designs. “Jaipur Watch Company, Ajwain, and Majestic Craftsman do pieces which represent the history and traditions of India,” he says. He describes Jaipur Watch Company’s hand-engraved ‘Baagh’ watch, gifted to him by his wife, as “more of an artefact than a mere watch”. Others are carving out distinct

identities, he says. Kala and Padigam draw from Indian art, culture and language, while Bengaluru Watch Company and Delhi Watch Company draw inspiration from contemporary India. This shift in perception — from a watch as a timekeeping device to an object of identity, design or sentiment — is at the heart of the newly emerging Indian microbrands. For a generation that can as easily check the time on a mobile phone, the proposition may seem counter-intuitive. Yet India’s watch market is estimated at about \$7 billion in 2026 and expected to grow more, even as consumers increasingly buy watches for reasons beyond utility. Argos believes smartwatches may have inadvertently helped create this opening. “The reason we exist, as do many other brands, are the smartwatches,” its spokesperson says. After a year of owning one, consumers typically realise that messages and calls are best handled by their phones. They then begin looking for something else. Mechanical watches offer a different kind of relationship, the spokesperson says. “It is indeed a mechanical rhythm happening on your wrist.” For enthusiasts, the appeal is in winding the watch and seeing through the transparent back case the rotor moving with the wrist. Indian brands are using the renewed interest to build differently. Jaipur Watch Company, founded by Gaurav Mehta, incorporates rare, vintage and historically significant elements, including old Indian coins, into watch dials. Bengaluru Watch Company has built collections around contemporary Indian themes drawn from the field of aviation and space to cricket and the outdoors. Its founders, Nirupesh Joshi and Mercy Amalraj, first developed an interest in watches when living and working in Hong Kong, where they could afford to buy Swiss and European luxury watches. Around 2012-13, the news that the government planned to shut the public sector company HMT’s watch operations prompted them to think about launching their Indian watch brand. MANUFACTURING GAP Founded in 2018, Bengaluru Watch Company now sells pieces priced between ₹1.5 lakh and ₹3 lakh. They, however, found that making a mechanical watch in India is not that straightforward. The company imports Swiss movements and uses Swiss-trained watchmakers to assemble, test and regulate the watches. Given the limited availability of skilled watchmakers, the company’s current capacity is restricted to 1,000-1,500 watches a year, the founders say.

Some firms face a wider ecosystem problem. “In India there is no integrated ecosystem for watch manufacturing, whereas China and Hong Kong have so many factories,” a company spokesperson says. While manufacturing may be cheaper in India, quality may be compromised, he says, with brands often forced to source components from multiple locations. The manufacturing gap, however, has not stopped brands from thinking of global expansion. “I’m not building an Indian brand for the world. I’m building a global brand that happens to be headquartered in India,” says Aakash Anand, co-founder and CEO of Rotoris. Priced anywhere from ₹75,000 to ₹8 lakh, Rotoris watches take their design cues from luxury objects — a superyacht, sports car, tuxedo or vintage car. The brand says 40 per cent of its revenue comes from the US and 10 per cent of its consumers are non-Indians. It has raised \$3 million seed funding, and plans to open 12 stores within three years. So, between mass-market Indian watchmakers and established international luxury brands, is there room for a home-grown player to build a meaningful consumer base? Apoorva Ranjan Sharma, co-founder of Venture Catalysts, believes there is. “Titan has scale, trust and distribution, while inter-

national brands have heritage. The space between them is for an independent Indian company capable of developing a distinct design language and maintaining pricing discipline.” BEYOND DESIGNS Archana Jahagirdar, Founder and Managing Partner, Rukam Capital, cautions that a brand cannot win simply by offering another well-designed watch. “For me, the question is not whether an Indian brand can displace Titan. It is whether it can create a new reason for consumers to choose it,” she says. Neha Singh, co-founder of Tracxn, notes that a scalable watch startup needs a sufficiently large addressable market, high gross margins, repeatable customer acquisition, a broad product portfolio and distribution. Some brands have demonstrated their hold beyond enthusiast communities. Argos’ revenue is growing, and it projects it would cross the ₹50-crore mark by the end of FY28. Boasting nearly equal sales in tier-I and tier-II cities, it plans to open at least three stores next year. The next growth phase for watch microbrands may be less about convincing consumers that watches still matter and more about why these particular watches matter — enough to pay a premium and recommend to others too.

STARTUPS: VAI-THIE-FUSS

Do venture capitalists know how to invest in deep tech?



This is the third and final instalment in the series on investing in deep-tech startups in India. The ecosystem is beginning to attract serious capital. Around 200 deep-tech startups have raised nearly \$2.3 billion so far this year, compared with \$1.62 billion raised by 453 startups in 2025, which is a 42 per cent growth in funding and more than thrice the average deal size. This suggests

some of the startups are graduating from experiments into enterprises. The government, too, has been supporting the sector. The ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme provides long-term financing in areas such as quantum computing, robotics, space, biotechnology, AI and energy. The Technology Development Board has approved 22 projects with RDI fund of ₹2,192 crore. So far, so good, but here’s the problem. For the past decade, Indian venture capital firms have become good at evaluating SaaS, e-commerce and consumer internet businesses. They have learnt to probe customer acquisition cost, monthly recurring revenue, gross

margins and lifetime value. As deep tech takes off, many of these VC firms have raised new funds to focus on this sunrise sector. But deep-tech startups require investors who understand what they are investing in. A semiconductor startup may spend years designing and testing a chip before meaningful revenues appear. A biotech startup could have excellent science but no commercial product for years. A space startup may literally burn millions before finding out if its technology works. The investor, thus, has to evaluate the technology before the spreadsheet. Among the space-tech startups, Pixxel has raised about \$195 million, while Skyroot has raised about

\$160 million. The investors are not evaluating conventional businesses but taking a view on rocket engines, satellites, imaging technology and markets that are still evolving. This creates an interesting new challenge for venture capital. Someone who has invested in SaaS companies for 10 years does not automatically acquire the ability to evaluate semiconductor architecture, synthetic biology, satellite technology or quantum computing simply by adding “deep tech” to the investment mandate. VC firms investing in deep tech will increasingly need scientists, engineers and domain specialists alongside MBAs and finance professionals. Technical due diligence could become as important as financial due diligence. Universities, research laboratories, retired scientists, industry veterans and successful deep-tech founders will need to become a part of the investment ecosystem. India is finally creating pools of patient capital for deep tech. But only knowledgeable capital can make the correct funding call. The past two decades have been about venture capitalists supporting engineers-turned-entrepreneurs. Perhaps it is now time to teach investors some serious engineering.

The writer is a serial entrepreneur and best-selling author of the book ‘Failing to Succeed’; posts on X @vaitheek

The attraction in a motor without magnets

How Vimag Labs’ workaround for a supply chain blockage birthed a new venture

Jyoti Banthia

For the electric vehicle industry, the motor is a familiar piece of engineering. But one component inside it increasingly figures in the supply-chain conversation: the permanent magnet. Vimag Labs is trying to remove it altogether. The Bengaluru-based deep-tech startup has developed a motor without permanent magnets — whether rare earth or ferrite. Instead it creates an electromagnet wirelessly inside the motor, using copper coils and current. The company calls it a “virtual magnet”. The idea was sparked by a supply chain crisis. Vimag had begun working on the underlying technology in late 2020, initially focusing on permanent magnet motors. During the Covid-19 pandemic, however, supply chain disruptions meant that magnets were stuck in transit for five to six months. This prompted the team to look for alternatives. Rather than accept the performance compromises in existing approaches, the company delved into the underlying physics of the motor.



MOTORHEAD. Manish Seth, Co-founder and CEO, Vimag Labs

The result is a motor architecture that Vimag believes can compete with the permanent magnet synchronous motor (PMSM) widely used in electric vehicles. Manish Seth, co-founder and CEO of Vimag Labs, says that internal tests show that the company’s motors are comparable to PMSM and, in some applications, perform better. Efficiency and range are at least comparable, the company says, while there’s an advantage in peak torque and power density. At the same time, Vimag does not want the technology to cost more than the PMSM. That proposition is now mov-

ing from the lab to customers. Vimag has received orders and is working with customers through the validation and production development stages. It is also testing with large European companies and is having prototype discussions with a large US industrial company. COMMERCIAL USES “We already have orders and are working on them to complete the validation, develop production and all of that,” Seth says. The first commercial applications are likely in electric two- and three-wheelers, where validation cycles are

generally shorter, before the technology moves to commercial vehicles and passenger cars. Vimag is also evaluating industrial systems, drones and robotics for applications. The company is currently setting up its manufacturing facility. It plans to keep the core electronics, motor-electronics integration, software and firmware segments in-house, while sourcing components such as shafts, bodies and laminations from outside. Its immediate priority is to complete the durability and regulatory validation, establish assembly lines and deliver its first units over the next 12 months. But removing magnets may not eliminate every supply chain vulnerability. Seth sees another choke point emerging in the electronics that control the motor. “The control chips, which are made by foreign companies only... That’s the next choke point, probably,” he says. Vimag, therefore, is betting beyond replacing one component. It is exploring whether a technology developed in response to one supply chain shock can offer manufacturers a way to reduce dependence on another.

‘Founder clarity trumps prototype’

bl.interview

Aishwarya Kumar

Early-stage investor Warmup Ventures favours what it calls the “Founder 3.0 cohort of entrepreneurs”. Co-founder Sharad Bansal explains what this means and how the fund is increasingly seeing such founders deliver “very, very outlier results”. Starting off as sector-agnostic, Warmup is focusing its second fund on deep-tech — including space, defence, manufacturing, and semiconductors — and consumer-enabling technology. Bansal sees policy support, indigenous procurement and shifting global supply chains creating a stronger case for backing deep-tech companies early. He outlines why founder clarity matters more than the prototype at the earliest stage, and why Warmup has resisted FOMO-driven investments. Edited excerpts: You have described India as entering a “Founder 3.0” phase. What does that mean? These are founders who have either done their first startup between 2011 and 2018, or have worked in unicorns or high-growth companies in technology, business, or marketing leadership roles. They have had exposure to building category leading companies. When these founders start companies, they are giving very, very outlier results. That has been



Founders with exposure to building category leading companies give very, very outlier results

SHARAD BANSAL
Co-founder, Warmup Ventures

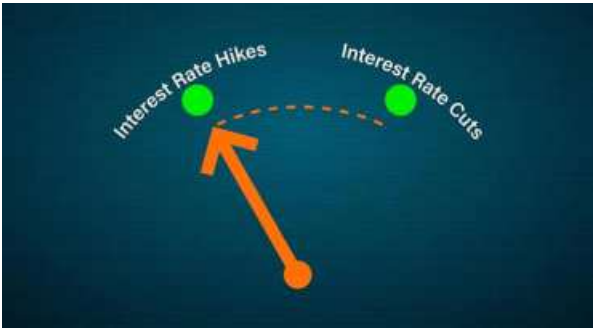
the kind of VC (venture capital) platform we are trying to build — a founders-led fund that backs experienced founders.

At the earliest stage, when several startups build similar products, what becomes the deciding factor? The primary filter is founder clarity. That can come from experience or from how much research the founder has done. What they can show today is not necessarily the real filter. We look at how they are thinking about the business one or two years down the line, what opportunities they see, how they plan to un-

lock them, and what their right to win is in becoming the No. 1 or No. 2 company in that category. Do Indian VCs still seek Western validation in emerging sectors such as biotech? The bottleneck in India is at the Series A level. We have good amounts of growth capital at the PE (private equity) stage and pre-seed and seed capital as well. The question is whether the company can raise a Series A. In biotech and pharma, the gestation cycle is long because product development takes time and companies need regulatory approvals. That creates a funding gap. You have also stayed away from some hyped deals. How do you avoid FOMO? A VC’s job is to filter itself from the FOMO. We have avoided companies where our capital would not make a difference — particularly situations where a celebrity founder’s first round is already valued at \$30-50 million or even \$100 million. If you are taking a significant risk by coming in extremely early, the valuation still must give you the desired reward for that risk. What is the biggest mistake you see founders making? Founders fall in love with the product instead of the solution. They become too attached to the product and are unwilling to pivot, and continue investing in something that may not be working.

NEWS SNIPPET.

Shallow rate hike imminent: SBI report



State Bank of India's Economic Research Department (ERD) expects a 25 basis point rate hike in the upcoming October policy, followed by a hike of similar quantum in December, factoring in the myriad evolving factors such as hardening crude oil prices, CPI inflation showing incipient signs of generalisation, and global bond yields inching past decadal highs.

"A shallow rate hike should serve many purposes at this juncture, most important being building confidence in agility of the RBI. Also, it can go a long way in RBI leading the way in setting the course, and tone for others (read Developed Markets) to follow," the ERD said in a report.

Just one month ago there was practically no talk of rate hikes, and the majority (if not all) expected a "prolonged pause", opined ERD officials. But the situation has changed drastically since then.

DATA BANK.

Banks outstrip NBFCs in credit offtake growth

As of July this year, outstanding credit of banks is 3.7 times that of non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), according to a report by Bank of Baroda's economic research department.

The share of NBFCs in the overall credit offtake was 21.3 per cent — a tad higher compared to 21.2 per cent in the previous month. However, growth of credit offtake is much steeper in the case of banks (19.3 per cent) compared with NBFCs (14.9 per cent), indicating the enduring role of banks as a major source of financing.

However, the sectoral picture gives some interesting insights.

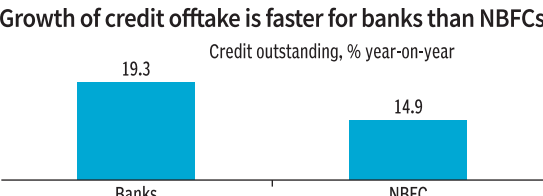
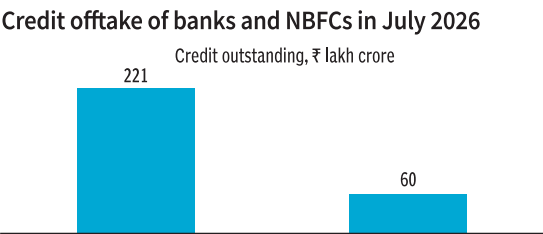
"Banks are maintaining a well-diversified portfolio with share of retail loans, services and industry capturing the space. For NBFCs, the share is skewed towards retail loans especially vehicle loan space and infrastructure space," Dipanwita Mazumdar, Economist, BoB, said in the report, titled 'Sectoral deployment of credit: Banks versus NBFCs'.

Further, banks are regaining their momentum in the infrastructure segment, as seen from the rising share in incremental credit in the current fiscal.

For some sectors such as commercial real estate and loan against gold jewellery, credit accretion in the current fiscal is much faster for banks, Mazumdar said.

"Incremental credit this fiscal shows that banks are maintaining a dominant share for majority of the sectors," the report said. The regaining of share by banks in the infrastructure space is interesting, as NBFCs had a higher share earlier, it added.

However, for some sectors such as commercial real estate and loans against gold jewellery, the rising incremental share of banks requires monitoring, the report said.



Sector-wise credit growth and share of NBFC vs bank

Sectors	Shares		Year-on-year	
	Banks	NBFCs	Banks	NBFCs
1. Agriculture etc	12.3	1.3	17.0	18.0
2. Industry	21.7	36.9	20.0	7.4
Infrastructure	6.9	33.7	10.2	6.2
Power	3.9	24.0	21.6	6.9
3. Services	28.1	12.8	22.9	15.2
Transport operators	1.3	3.0	8.0	10.7
Trade	6.4	1.9	19.8	14.7
Commercial real estate	3.0	1.7	21.5	22.3
4. Retail loans	32.5	43.5	16.2	21.4
Housing loans	15.5	14.3	11.3	11.9
Vehicle loans	3.5	10.5	18.8	15.1
Loans against gold jewellery	2.5	5.9	88.1	68.5
Consumer durables	0.1	1.2	0.4	51.5
5. Other loans	-	5.4	-	19.7

Sectors	Incremental credit over March-July 2026		Share of banks
	Banks	NBFCs	
1. Agriculture etc	62,402	2,712	95.8
2. Industry	2,16,472	6,087	97.3
Infrastructure	22,682	102	99.6
Power	26,678	15,093	63.9
3. Services	1,35,521	19,572	87.4
Transport operators	3,616	3,528	50.6
Trade	32,317	1,846	94.6
Commercial real estate	42,142	4,284	111.3
4. Retail loans	2,43,585	1,67,585	59.2
Housing loans	72,490	33,159	68.6
Vehicle loans	25,877	25,488	50.4
Loans against gold jewellery	90,888	43,851	67.5
Consumer durables	1,065	15,821	6.3
5. Other loans	17,103	0.0	
Overall credit	7,16,660	2,13,060	77.1

Source: RBI, Bank of Baroda Research

● BRIGHT PROSPECTS

Big NBFCs join the gold loan mela

DAZZLING GROWTH. Liquid collateral proves irresistible to non-banks battling asset quality woes in unsecured loans

K Ram Kumar

The big daddies in the gold loan space, such as Muthoot Finance and Manappuram Finance, have some serious competition coming their way as diversified large non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) are entering their turf, given that lending in this space is secure, recovery easy and non-performing assets low.

Diversified NBFCs such as Tata Capital, Aditya Birla Capital, L&T Finance and Godrej Capital have taken a plunge in this space either through the acquisition of smaller, specialised gold loan players or branch expansion plans.

This comes in the backdrop of unsecured credit and microfinance segments seeing asset quality cycles.

The lure of this business can be gauged from the credit growth of NBFCs in the loans against gold jewellery (LAGJ) segment. They notched up a 68.5 per cent year-on-year (yoy) credit growth in the LAGJ business as at July-end 2026, against 43.9 per cent as at July-end 2025, as per RBI data.

"NBFCs are giving gold loans at 12–18 per cent interest rate. Since gold is liquid collateral, the question for lenders is: Why take the risk of unsecured lending at 12–18 per cent when they can get a secured business at similar rates?"

"Gold loans are also short-tenor loans, generally one year or less. While there may be some variation in non-performing assets (NPAs), the ultimate loss from a default is negligible because the lender has the gold as collateral. That is what is enticing everybody," said a senior official with a credit rating agency (CRA).

SURGING AUM

Gold loan assets under management (AUM) has grown sharply over the last couple of years, largely because of the rise in gold prices. NBFCs' LAGJ portfolio has more than doubled in the last two years from ₹1,45,986 crore as at July-end 2025 to ₹3,53,988 crore as at July-end 2026.

As at June-end 2026, Mut-



TRUE TEST. With gold prices surging, borrowers are able to get a bigger loan against it BLOOMBERG

hoot Finance and Manappuram Finance had standalone gold loan AUM of ₹1,63,299 crore and ₹54,655 crore, respectively.

Gold price jumped from about ₹69,000 per 10 gm as at July-end 2024 to a peak of about ₹1.64 lakh as at January-end 2026, and currently rules at about ₹1.54 lakh.

Given the rise in the yellow metal's price, borrowers are able to get a bigger loan against it. "Gold prices have been stable or marginally down over the last six months. The key question is whether this shift towards gold loans can continue."

"There is a view that gold prices will not crash, given their historical performance and the prevailing global uncertainties. If loans are short-tenor, borrowers generally repay them sooner or refinance them with another lender. So, the industry is currently riding the momentum," the CRA official said.

Ajay Manglunia, Executive Director, Capri Global Finance Ltd, said that unlike unsecured loans, gold loans offer lenders strong collateral security. So, if a borrower defaults, the lender can follow the required formalities, auction the gold and recover the money. As a result, the asset quality is generally better in the case of gold loans

than other loan categories.

Since gold loans are secured and there have been asset quality challenges in the unsecured loans and microfinance segments, some of the larger NBFCs are positioning themselves as lenders with more secured assets and lower unsecured exposure. This is helping build a narrative that their book is safer than that of their peers.

GROWTH PLANS

A year ago, L&T Finance Ltd (LTF) acquired the gold loan business of Paul Merchants Finance Pvt Ltd (PMFL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Paul Merchants Ltd. This acquisition included PMFL's 130 branches, nearly 700 employees, and the business transfer of its ₹1,350-crore gold loan book to LTF, marking its entry into gold loans.

Sudipta Roy, MD and CEO, said, "Gold loans will be one of our fastest-growing businesses. We expect the gold loan portfolio to expand from about ₹3,000 crore today to nearly ₹40,000 crore by 2031.

"Inorganic growth is not our primary strategy, but we remain open to opportunities that satisfy three conditions: They are of an easily integrable size; they fill a strategic capability gap; and they are available at an attractive valuation. That

was the rationale behind our acquisition in the gold loan business."

In July this year, Tata Capital Ltd (TCL) announced that its board had approved the proposed acquisition of Yogakshemam Loans Ltd (Yogloans), an RBI-registered NBFC primarily focused on gold loans. This signals TCL's entry into the gold loan business.

Yogloans operates through a network of 162 branches across Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Andhra Pradesh, with AUM of ₹708 crore as of March 31. The company serves around 32,000 gold loan customers and has built strong capabilities in sourcing, underwriting and servicing in its decade-plus presence in the gold loan business.

Godrej Capital, through its subsidiary Godrej Finance Ltd, also announced the acquisition of the gold loan business of Kanakadurga Finance Ltd in July. This is the company's first strategic acquisition and marks its entry into gold loans.

The acquisition gives Godrej Finance about ₹280 crore AUM, nearly 12,000 customers, 54 operational branches across Andhra Pradesh, and a team of around 250 employees.

Pankaj Gupta, MD and CEO, Godrej Finance, said, "Gold loans are one of India's fastest-growing secured lending cat-

egories, supported by increasing formalisation, strong customer demand and growing preference for organised lenders. We view this as a category with significant long-term potential."

He emphasised that the Kanakadurga acquisition came at the right time, as local expertise, customer trust and operating experience are valuable assets in a gold loan business.

"This acquisition accelerated our entry into the gold loan category by providing access to experienced teams, trusted customer relationships and deep market understanding, while allowing it to build on an established franchise rather than starting from scratch," Gupta said.

Last month, Aditya Birla Capital Ltd (ABCL) announced its entry into the gold loan business. It plans to open 1,000 gold loan branches in the next three years.

Bajaj Finance is revving up its gold loans business. In the first quarter of FY27, the NBFC added 194 gold loan branches, taking the total to 1,701 (from 1,254 branches as at June-end 2025). The company expects to close FY27 with a network of about 2,800 gold loan branches.

A gold loan industry expert observed that there is interest across the market. Players such as IIFL Finance and Capri Global Finance have also become fairly significant in the gold loan segment. Most of this growth happened over the last one and a half years. Therefore, when one looks at year-on-year numbers, the percentage jump is quite sharp.

"We have not really seen a full gold loan cycle. In unsecured lending and microfinance, we have seen bad cycles. But gold has steadily appreciated over the last five to seven years. So, we have not experienced a similar downturn in gold lending. That is something to watch. Otherwise, the near-term outlook appears fairly positive," the expert said.

With the "gold rush" among large NBFCs, competition in the gold loans segment is expected to heat up further.

Gold loan rates may also start to fall, depending on how aggressively the new entrants want to compete.

A nuanced take on life insurance 'surrenders'

Why a need-based withdrawal should not automatically be construed as policy rejection or evidence of mis-selling



ADITYA GUPTA

The recent discussions on the high rate of life insurance surrenders and the likely role played by mis-selling are important and deserve attention. Mis-selling, wherever it occurs, must be addressed firmly. At the same time, aggregate surrender figures should be interpreted with care. The word "surrender" in life insurance statistics covers a wide range of customer behaviour and product structures, and does not always mean that a customer has rejected insurance or the original sale was unsuitable.

TERMINOLOGY MATTERS

Life insurance and mutual funds use different terminology for similar customer actions. For example, a unit-linked insurance plan (ULIP) combines insurance protection with market-linked investment. After the lock-in period, a policyholder may choose to withdraw or redeem the accumulated value. In the insurance industry, such an exit may be recorded as a "surrender", while it is generally described as "redemption" in the mutual fund industry.

The terminology can, therefore, create an impression that every exit represents a failure of the insurance product, when in reality it may simply be the customer's decision to access accumulated funds.

LONG-TERM INTENT

Many life insurance products are deliberately designed with long policy durations because



THAT'S LIFE. Medical expense, child's education, or retirement can alter a policyholder's liquidity needs

insurance is fundamentally a long-term financial commitment. At the same time, depending on the nature and terms of the product, customers may have access to benefits such as partial withdrawals, surrender or other permitted exit options. An urgent medical expense, a child's education, a family event, retirement needs or a change in financial priorities can alter the customer's liquidity requirements.

Exercising an available exit or withdrawal option in such circumstances should not automatically be construed as dissatisfaction with the product or evidence of mis-selling.

To put things in perspective, the ratio of surrender payouts to total life insurance premium collected during the year has progressively increased from 21 per cent in FY20 to 26 per cent in FY25, largely due to the availability of surrender in ULIPs after the 2024 IRDAI regulations.

Since ULIPs generally have a

lock-in period and combine insurance protection with market-linked investment features, it is apparent that customers have 'redeemed' or 'cashed out' their investment rather than 'surrendered' it.

It is always likely that the customer has invested the proceeds in another protection/savings policy to improve their financial resilience.

NATURE OF PRODUCT

A meaningful assessment should distinguish between pure protection products and fund-based or savings-oriented insurance products. For a pure term insurance policy, a surrender or early discontinuance may indeed be a more direct signal that the policyholder no longer wishes to retain the protection. But for ULIPs, participating savings products, and certain single-premium products that combine risk cover with investment or capital appreciation, customer exits can reflect investment de-

cisions, liquidity needs or changes in financial priorities.

'EXIT' NOT END OF COVER

In some cases, a policyholder may alter the policy, withdraw value, or reduce the cover without completely ending the insurance relationship or all the associated risk protection. Therefore, equating every recorded surrender with termination may oversimplify the actual customer journey.

THE RIGHT MEASURE

The objective should be to identify genuine mis-selling without unintentionally portraying every customer exit as evidence. A more informative analysis would distinguish between pure protection and fund-based products; surrender, partial withdrawal, maturity and other exit routes; exits before and after lock-in periods; customer-initiated liquidity events; and policies where risk cover continues

after a change in policy value or benefits. Such a segmentation would provide a far more accurate picture of customer behaviour and product suitability.

MITIGATING SURRENDERS

To offer a more personalised approach, various life insurers have mandated a personal intervention process. Customers are counselled about the probability of new policies being offered at a higher rate due to advanced age and adverse medical conditions. Where the policy has been in force only for a short duration, the customer is apprised that the surrender value may not even cover the paid premiums. To help fulfil the temporary need for funds, insurers are offering loan against policies or facilitating partial withdrawal in ULIPs. Future communication campaigns will direct attention towards these measures in a bid to educate customers about the pitfalls of policy surrenders.

A BALANCED CONCLUSION

High surrender numbers should certainly prompt questions, but they should not become a proxy for mis-selling. The life insurance sector must continue to improve transparency, suitability assessment, and customer education. At the same time, the public discourse should recognise that modern insurance products increasingly provide customers with flexibility and liquidity options.

A customer who chooses a long-term product with an open option to access funds when needed is not necessarily rejecting life insurance; they may simply be exercising the flexibility that the product was designed to provide.

The writer is Secretary General, Life Insurance Council

QUICKLY.
SC rejects Reliance
Comm creditors’ plea



Mumbai: The Supreme Court has dismissed an SBI-led review petition calling for the reconsideration of Reliance Communications’ spectrum as part of the insolvency pool under the IBC code. In an order dated July 28, Justices PS Narasimha and Atul Chandurkar rejected the plea filed by the Committee of Creditors (CoC) challenging an earlier apex court verdict that excluded spectrum as an “asset” for insolvency and liquidation. The petitioners argued that the asset under consideration was not the spectrum itself but the legally enforceable right to use spectrum. The petition challenged an earlier February 13 judgment that deemed spectrum as an asset not viable to be sold. VALLARI SANJIGIRI

Bharucha, K Balasubramanian in race for HDFC Bank top job

Our Bureau
Mumbai

HDFC Bank’s board may have shortlisted the names of its Deputy Managing Director Kaizad Bharucha and K Balasubramanian, Citi’s Chief Country Officer for India, for getting Reserve Bank of India’s approval to appoint one of them as the bank’s chief. The central bank usually requires private sector banks to propose two names, who will fit the bill in terms of its “fit and proper” criteria, for the top position. While HDFC Bank veteran Bharucha’s appointment will signal that its business as usual, selection of Balasubramanian, who has been with Citi for about three decades, will inject fresh blood into

Agnikul bets on sustainable rocket manufacturing as space race heats up

LIFT-OFF SOON. The company is expanding its manufacturing and testing capabilities in Tamil Nadu

Aishwarya Kumar
Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

India is emerging as an increasingly attractive launch destination for global satellite companies, with space start-up Agnikul Cosmos receiving one to two launch enquiries every week, Co-Founder and CEO Srinath Ravichandran said. “A large share of the enquiries is coming from international customers, as satellite operators increasingly seek dedicated launches to specific orbital parameters,” he said. The trend comes as India’s track record in satellite launch services and the growing credibility of its private space sector strengthen the country’s po-



We plan to operate from multiple launch facilities, including Sriharikota
SRINATH RAVICHANDRAN
Co-Founder and CEO

sition in the global launch market. **ORBITAL PRECISION** Agnikul is now preparing to move to commercial operations, with an ambition to

scale its annual launch cadence to 100 missions. The company expects individual reusable launch vehicles to be capable of 10–12 flights. The company is also expanding its manufacturing

and testing capabilities in Tamil Nadu, including infrastructure closer to the upcoming Kulasekarapattinam spaceport. For small-satellite operators, while rideshare missions can offer a lower launch cost per kilogram, satellites are typically deployed into a shared or predetermined orbit and may subsequently require onboard propulsion. This can add complexity to the satellite, while also consuming mass. A dedicated launch vehicle, therefore, can offer value by placing a payload closer to its required orbital parameters. For Agnikul, the proposition is more about providing precise orbital deployment.

COST STRUCTURE The company also expects the Indian satellite ecosys-

tem to contribute significantly to its commercial launch manifest. A key part of Agnikul’s longer-term strategy is reusability, which the company sees as a way to change the cost structure of launch operations. For an expendable rocket, a chunk of the manufacturing process has to be repeated for every mission. A reusable vehicle, by contrast, shifts a greater proportion of the recurring cost towards inspection, refurbishment, testing and re-qualification. Agnikul is also manufacturing multiple launch vehicles in parallel. The approach is intended to avoid a model in which the company builds a single vehicle, flies it, analyses the results and only then begins production of the next vehicle.

Tata Sons to table listing mandate on Thursday

Akshata Gorde
Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

After the Reserve Bank of India turned down its request for de-registration as a core investment company, Tata Sons is expected to discuss the next steps on Thursday. While the company’s plan of action in the matter remains unknown, lawyers say it can explore a legal review or seek a transitional dispensation from the RBI for listing its shares. **‘CAN SEEK TIME’** “Tata Sons will likely need to engage with the RBI and establish a compliance roadmap for its continuing status as an NBFC–Upper Layer. This includes addressing the mandatory listing requirement, which originally

● **‘WITHOUT PREJUDICE’**
The RBI NBFC-UL list released on August 6 had 17 NBFCs including Tata Sons. The central bank had then said that inclusion of Tata Sons in the list is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for re-registration

applied within three years of its upper-layer classification in September 2022,” Alay Razvi, Managing Partner of law firm Accord Juris, told *businessline*. Tata Sons can also seek re-consideration or request additional time, although the outcome would depend on the RBI’s response, he added. While a writ petition against the Reserve Bank of India’s action is possible, lawyers point that a court is unlikely to substitute its view for RBI’s on matters of financial sector regulation. According to Rizvi, courts

generally do not substitute commercial or regulatory assessment of regulators unless the decision is legally irrational, procedurally unfair or contrary to the governing law. **TIME-BOUND** “The immediate regulatory posture necessitates that the entity (Tata Sons) either seeks formal reconsideration, requests an appropriate transitional dispensation from the Reserve Bank of India, or initiates a judicial challenge against the administrative determination,”

said advocate Yash Joglekar. The central bank’s NBFC–Upper Layer list released on August 6 had 17 non-banking financial companies, including Tata Sons. The central bank had then said that inclusion of Tata Sons in the list is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for re-registration. “The mere pendency of the deregistration application may have temporarily stayed coercive regulatory enforcement, but it did not extinguish the underlying listing covenant absent an express regulatory directive, meaning the entity (Tata Sons) is now compelled to furnish a strictly time-bound, irrevocable listing roadmap subject to the regulator’s discretion and any interim judicial relief,” Joglekar added.

Tata Sons listing to unlock ₹1.20-lakh cr value for 7 group cos

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Some of the listed Tata Group entities will get re-rated with the RBI making it mandatory for Tata Sons to list on the stock exchanges. Seven listed Tata Group companies cumulatively own 11.6 per cent stake worth ₹1.20 lakh crore in Tata Sons. Among them, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicle and Tata Steel own the highest equity stake of 3.06 per cent each while Tata Chemicals and Tata Power have 2.53 per cent and 1.65 per cent stake, respectively. Similarly, Indian Hotel has 1.11 per cent stake while Tata Consumers and Tata Investment own 0.43 per cent and 0.25 per cent, respectively.

THE NUMBERS At the market estimated value of ₹10 lakh crore of Tata Sons, the stake of Tata Steel and Tata Motors PV in Tata Sons will be valued at ₹30,600 crore each while that of Tata Chemicals and Tata Power will be ₹25,300 crore and ₹16,500 crore, respectively. Indian Hotels’ stake will be valued at ₹11,100 crore. The holding of Tata Consumers and Tata Investment will be valued at ₹4,300 crore and ₹2,500 crore, respectively. The Tata Sons holding will be 13 per cent of Tata Steel’s current market capitalisation of ₹2.28 lakh crore while it will be more than 100 per cent of Tata Chemicals’

₹15,603 crore market cap. Similarly, Tata Sons holding of Tata Motors PV will be valued at 30 per cent of its market cap while for Tata Power and Indian Hotels it will be in the 10–14 per cent range. The impact on Tata Consumers and Tata Investments will be marginal given their low stake holding. Though it is not clear whether the listed companies will dilute their stake in Tata Sons’ expected IPO, none of the shareholders, except the Shapoorji Pallonji Group, have shown an interest. The SP Group holds 18.37 per cent equity stake in Tata Sons.

GOOD FOR COMPANIES? Tata Chemicals stands to gain the most, especially since its holding represents a significant value compared to its own market capitalisation, said Piyush Jhunjhunwala, CEO and founder, Stockify. Tata Investment Corporation and some other companies within the group could also see considerable value unlocking from Tata Sons listing. The possible gains arise from the realisation of the actual value of the holdings as per market expectations instead of them being a mere entry in the companies’ books, he said. Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager, Alpha AMC, said: “The proceeding of the September 17 board meeting needs to be watched closely, since succession and the listing roadmap are both likely to come up there.”

Who holds how much

	Stake in Tata Sons (%)	Value (in ₹ crore)
Tata Steel	3.06	30,600
Tata Motors PV	3.06	30,600
Tata Chemicals	2.53	25,300
Indian Hotels	1.11	11,100
Tata Consumers	0.43	4,300
Tata Investment	0.25	2,500
Tata Power	1.65	16,500

India-EU FTA gives Tata Motors, Bajaj Auto, JSW a foot on both sides of the tariff wall

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India’s proposed free trade agreement with the European Union is set to open the country’s automobile market in phases, but the bigger story may be the strategic flexibility it creates for automakers. While European luxury cars and superbikes will gain faster access through lower tariffs, companies such as Tata Motors, Bajaj Auto and potentially JSW Group could find themselves benefiting from both sides of the trade arrangement.

CHANGING EQUATION Detailed tariff schedules disclosed on September 11

show a two-speed opening of the market. European-built petrol, diesel and non-plug-in hybrid passenger vehicles get an early entry route, while electric vehicles and commercial trucks face tighter quotas and slower tariff reductions. Under the agreement, qualifying European cars priced above €35,000 can enter India at a 30 per cent duty in year 1, compared with 13.75 per cent on completely knocked down (CKD) kits assembled locally. By year 5, the rates fall to 10 per cent and 8.25 per cent respectively, reducing the tariff advantage enjoyed by local assembly from 16.25 percentage points to just 1.75 points. “The real significance of



GOOD NEWS. Duty on qualifying European motorcycles above 800cc falls from 55% to 32.5%

the FTA is not simply that imported European vehicles become cheaper. It changes the product-planning equation,” said Avik Chattopadhyay, Brand Strategy, Mar-

keting and Automotive Product Planning Expert. “High-volume products can continue to be made or assembled in India, while niche, performance and halo

models can be imported from Europe.” The shift could give luxury carmakers such as Mercedes-Benz, BMW, Audi and Volvo greater flexibility to reserve Indian assembly capacity for high-volume products while expanding their imported portfolios. For JSW’s proposed partnership with Skoda Volkswagen India, the agreement provides additional breathing room in EVs. European-built battery EVs and plug-in hybrids receive no preferential import quota during the first four years of the pact. A 20,000-unit concessional import window opens only in year 5, with tariffs gradually declining thereafter. That effectively gives

manufacturers time to localise higher-volume EV production. “You can test the market with an imported product and localise it when the volumes justify the investment,” said Chattopadhyay. The duty on qualifying European motorcycles above 800cc falls from 55 per cent to 32.5 per cent when the agreement comes into force and further to 10 per cent from year 2. **THE CV STORY** Commercial vehicles remain more protected. The combined quota for imported trucks and CKD kits starts at 5,000 units and gradually doubles by year 10. For Tata Motors, the proposed acquisition of Iveco

could add another layer of strategic advantage. When completed, the truck maker would also own a European company eligible to benefit from the same tariff opening.

“The FTA could change how automakers allocate capital,” said Kranthi Bathini, Director – Equity Strategy, WealthMills Securities.

FTA gives India 6.94 lakh tonnes of steel quota annually for exports

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India will get country-specific tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) totalling 1.64 million tonnes annually for exporting steel products to the European Union, of which 6,94,853 tonnes will be under the free trade agreement, per the draft text of the pact.

The total country-specific quota of 16,41,470 tonnes comprises 9,46,616 tonnes under the most favoured nation) component. That, along with FTA quota, covers a wide range of steel products including cold-rolled sheets, pipes and tubes. India, at present, exports about four million tonnes of steel per year to the EU.

Global Fintech Fest 2026: Big ideas, bigger crowds and a reality check

Away from the numbers and sessions, GFF had all the familiar signs of a trade fair

Our Bureau
Mumbai

More than a lakh people walked through the doors of the recently concluded three-day Global Fintech Fest 2026 (GFF) in Mumbai. The real story, however, was not the crowd, rather who was in the room, and what they spoke about. As 1,200 speakers took the stage, over 500 investors, 350-plus exhibitors and 100-plus regulators and policymakers from across the world debated fintech’s future. In 2025, GFF had already established its scale — with 1 lakh-plus footfall, 8,000-plus companies, 1,000-plus speakers, 500-plus investors and a packed calendar of sessions. GFF 2026 demonstrated its depth. With participation from nearly 77 countries, the fest



BUZZING. Crowd outside a Paytm booth at the Global Fintech Fest in Mumbai on September 11 BLOOMBERG

drew more than 8,500 institutions and over 250 product launches and showcases. The most interesting conversations often happened away from the main stage — with regulators fielding questions from fintech founders in closed-door sessions, investors comparing notes on what would actually scale, and

companies using the exhibition floor to turn AI and tokenisation from buzzwords into demos. **TWO SIDES TO IT** Away from the big numbers and headline sessions, GFF had all the familiar signs of a trade fair where everyone was trying to be noticed. Start-ups and fintech firms used the exhibition

floor as a giant introduction deck — pitching products to investors, cornering company executives and handing out demos, brochures and business cards. Company logos were everywhere with executives and founders turning branded jackets, T-shirts and badges into walking billboards. What stood out was how often conversations moved beyond fintech into the larger architecture of India’s digital economy. The scale, however, came with its own challenges. While GFF aimed to showcase the cutting edge of fintech, the pavilions often felt like victims of their own success. Ground-breaking innovations competed for attention amid crushing crowds, overlapping music and a steady stream of product launches and announcements.

Copper remains a costly necessity for firms

Our Bureaus

Electronic goods and consumer appliance prices are set to be increased significantly this month, while another hike is likely in the next quarter, according to industry officials. Avneesh Singh Marwah, CEO, SPPL, the Indian licensee of brands such as Kodak, Blaupunkt and Thomson, said: “All ‘A-Class components’, including copper, have seen a surge in price. We are hiking prices by 7 per cent this month and will look at another hike in the next quarter.” Haier Appliances India MD NS Satish said, “We have, in the past few months, taken a price increase of 10–12 per cent. We may take a marginal hike of about 2 per cent in October in the mid and premium segments.”

RIPPLE EFFECT Ajinkya Firodia, MD of Kinetic Engineering, said higher copper prices are another

● **NEED MORE**
An ICE passenger vehicle has about 20–25 kg of copper, compared to 80–85 kg in some electric cars

headwind for EV economics. An ICE passenger vehicle contains about 20–25 kg of copper, compared with 80–85 kg in some electric cars, while an ICE two-wheeler uses 2.5–3 kg against 8–10 kg for an electric model. An electric bus can require 250–300 kg. BGauss Founder and MD Hemant Kabra said: “Copper is not a material that an EV manufacturer can simply eliminate.” For commercial-EV customers, every rupee matters because the purchase decision is based on total cost of ownership, said Uday Narang, Chairman and Founder of Omega Seiki Mobility. Appliance makers can substitute aluminium for copper

in selected applications, though brands have long marketed “100 per cent copper” condensers as a performance and durability advantage. Dhairyashil Patil, National President of the All India Consumer Products Distributors Federation, said: “Our concern is that companies may use the sharp increase in copper and other input costs as another reason to squeeze distributor margins, which are already under pressure,” said. A senior industry executive in New Delhi said leading companies are focusing on stocking up raw material and components in advance for the festival season. “The inventories are usually for about 2–3 months. So margin pressures are likely to increase in the coming weeks,” he said.

With inputs from Rohan Das, Chennai; AJ Vinayak, Mangaluru; Meenakshi Verma Ambwani, New Delhi; Aishwarya Nandakumar, Bengaluru, Amit Vinay Mohile and Vallari Sanjigiri, Mumbai